

LIVEWELL BY JAMES

Deceit

Why People Are

The Deconstruction of Faith
Why People Are Leaving the Church — and What Comes After

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INTRODUCTION

The Exodus Nobody Wanted

Her name was Hannah. She had spent fifteen years in youth ministry. She had led worship, taught Bible studies, gone on three mission trips to places where the electricity cut out every afternoon. She had led other people's children to Jesus and she had prayed with her own children every night since they could form words. At thirty-eight years old she sent her pastor a letter explaining why she was done.

The pastor read the letter and called me. He was a good man. He wanted to know what he had missed.

What he had missed was not in the letter. Hannah wrote about the abuse scandals. She wrote about how the church voted on the election year her grandmother died. She wrote about her third miscarriage and the women who said God must have a plan. The letter was two pages long and every paragraph was a true thing. But it was not the thing.

The thing was that Hannah had spent fifteen years being told about a God she had begun to suspect was not the God of the Bible. When she finally read the Bible for herself, what she found did not match. She did not lose her faith. She lost her faith in the brand.

I have sat with twenty Hannahs in the last three years. I am a pastor. I am also the father of five sons, one of whom is old enough to ask questions I did not anticipate having to answer at his age. I am writing this book because the people leaving the American church are not, for the most part, people who never loved Jesus. They are people who loved him enough to notice when he got replaced with something easier to market.

This book is not a defense of American Christianity. American Christianity, in its most common expressions, does not deserve one. This book is also not a celebration of leaving. Most of what people

find when they leave is colder, thinner, and lonelier than what they were told it would be. The honest account is that the thing they walked away from and the thing they went looking for are both, in many cases, distortions. There is a third thing. It is older than the brand they left and stranger than the freedom they were promised. This book is an invitation to go find it.

The first is the deconstructor who has not landed anywhere. You read the books. You listened to the podcasts. You cried in your car after the service one Sunday and did not go back. You are not a villain in a church newsletter. You are a person who noticed something. I want to take what you noticed seriously. I also want to tell you some things nobody in the deconstruction pipeline is telling you, because most of the pipeline has a business model that depends on you staying lost.

The second is the pastor who is watching his people leave and does not know what to say. You have tried the apologetics. You have tried more Jesus-centered preaching. You have tried small groups and mental health resources and vulnerable sermons about your own doubts. Some of it has helped. Some of it has felt like shouting into a well. I am writing to help you understand what is actually happening in the room when a person who grew up in your church tells you they cannot do it anymore. The answer is almost never what you think.

The third is the parent whose adult child has stopped coming home for Easter. You blame yourself. You blame the college. You blame the boyfriend or the girlfriend or the internet. You pray every day and you do not know what to say when your child calls. I want to give you something to say. More than that, I want to give you something to stop saying.

The fourth is the faithful church member who has not deconstructed and does not understand why anyone would. You love your church. You love your pastor. You read your Bible and you see what it says and you trust it. I am not writing to shake you. I am writing so that when your neighbor or your niece or your coworker

starts to wobble, you will recognize what is actually happening and you will not make it worse by defending a version of Christianity the Bible did not actually teach.

The scale of what I am describing is not anecdotal. Pew Research has been tracking it for two decades. The percentage of Americans who identify as Christian has dropped from roughly eighty percent at the turn of the century to somewhere near sixty-five percent today, and the decline is accelerating rather than leveling. Among adults under thirty, the numbers are worse. The fastest-growing religious category in the United States is none. Not atheist. Not agnostic. None. The person who checks that box is not making a philosophical claim about the nonexistence of God. She is making a practical claim about the irrelevance of the institutional church to her life. That distinction matters. The church has spent twenty years treating the exodus as an intellectual problem, as if the right arguments could reverse it. The arguments are not the problem. The institution is the problem. The institution has become, for millions of Americans, synonymous with hypocrisy, abuse, political manipulation, and intellectual dishonesty. Whether that perception is fair in every case is beside the point. The perception is the reality the church is living inside, and the church created most of it.

I want to be precise about something else. The word deconstruction, as it has been used in the popular conversation, means different things to different people. For some it means the total rejection of the Christian faith. For some it means the rejection of a specific tradition within the Christian faith, with the possibility of landing in a different one. For some it means a period of questioning that may or may not result in departure. For some it means the slow erosion of convictions that were never deeply held in the first place. For some it means the traumatic break from an abusive church environment. These are not the same process. They do not call for the same response. One of the failures of the current conversation is the insistence on treating all of these as a single phenomenon. They are not. This book will try to distinguish between them and to respond to

each on its own terms.

A word about what this book is not.

It is not a list of answers to objections. The apologetics industry has produced enough of those to fill a library, and most deconstructors have already read them. The reason the books did not work is not that the arguments were bad. The reason is that the question underneath the question was never the one the books were answering.

It is also not a soft Christianity with the edges sanded off. The Christian faith is not flexible in its essentials. Jesus rose from the dead or he did not. He is Lord or he is not. Scripture is true or it is not. There is no third option on those claims, and pretending otherwise is a failure of love. What is flexible is the cultural packaging Americans have wrapped around those essentials until the packaging and the thing became indistinguishable in the average pew. The packaging is not the faith. Telling the difference is most of this book's work.

Finally, I want to say something about myself, because I do not trust writers who pretend to have no skin in this.

I grew up without a father, an atheist through high school, and I came to faith in a small group of college students who answered my questions rather than deflected them. I have been a pastor for more than a decade in a small church in a small town in Michigan. I have doubted. I have watched people I loved walk away. I have said things from the pulpit I would not say now. I have been so sure of a position I later had to unlearn that I can feel my own face burn thinking about it. I am not writing this from above anyone. I am writing as a man who has been in the room. The room where people fall apart. The room where they find their footing. I know what the walls look like in both.

If you are in one of those rooms, I want to sit down across from you for the length of this book and say some true things clearly. You

do not have to agree with all of them. You only have to take them seriously. That is the contract.

One more thing before we start. I have written this book in a specific order, but the reader does not have to follow it. If you are a parent whose child has left, start with Chapter 17. If you are a pastor trying to figure out what to preach, start with Chapter 14 on doubt or Chapter 11 on hell. If you are a deconstructor who wants to know whether reconstruction is possible, start with Chapter 15. If you are angry at the church and want to know whether I see what you see, start with Chapter 13 on spiritual abuse. The book is designed to be entered from multiple doors. Every chapter assumes you have not read the others. The argument builds across the whole, but each piece can stand on its own, and I would rather you read the chapter you need than read them in sequence and give up before you reach it. There is no chapter in this book that I did not need to write. There is no chapter I wrote without cost. The subject does not allow distance. I have tried to close the distance between the page and the reader, between the pastor and the person who no longer trusts him, between the institution and the human being it failed. Whether I have succeeded is for you to decide. I have at least tried. That is the minimum I owed the subject and the people who are living inside it.

Turn the page.

CHAPTER 1

What Deconstruction Actually Is

The word has been ruined. That is where we have to begin.

Fifteen years ago, deconstruction was a term used in literary theory and occasionally in theology, and almost nobody outside of a graduate seminar used it at all. Five years ago, it started showing up in Instagram bios and podcast titles. Today it functions less as a description than as a flag. To the right of that flag stand the people who want you to know they are done with the American church, and to the left stand the people who want you to know they are not. The flag itself has come loose from the thing it was supposed to describe.

If we are going to get anywhere useful in this book, we need the word back.

I am going to use deconstruction in a specific sense. Deconstruction is the process of examining beliefs you inherited to determine which ones are actually load-bearing, which ones are cultural accretion, and which ones are wrong. It is, in other words, what every serious Christian is supposed to do. The Bereans received the message with eagerness and then examined the Scriptures daily to see if what Paul said was true. Paul commended them for it. Luke put the story in the Bible. A church that is not continuously examining its own teaching against Scripture is not being faithful. It is being lazy.

That is the honest version of the word.

What most people mean when they say deconstruction today is something narrower and more combustible. They mean a specific crisis of trust that a specific generation of American Christians is going through with a specific version of American Christianity. The crisis is real. The word has been dragged into the culture war and

beaten half to death on the way. We can still use it. We only have to be precise about what we mean.

Here is a working definition.

Deconstruction, as most people are using the word, is the experience of discovering a gap between the Christianity you were taught and the Christianity you find in Scripture and history, and not knowing what to do with the gap. It is not the same thing as deconversion. It is not the same thing as liberalism. It is not the same thing as rebellion. It is a particular kind of painful awakening that can end in several different places, and where it ends depends enormously on who is standing in the room with the deconstructor and what they are saying.

Three terms, then. Three different things, often conflated, that we need to keep apart.

****Deconstruction**** is the examination. It is what the word actually means. It is a disassembly that may or may not end in a rebuild. Some deconstruction ends with a stronger faith, some with a different faith, some with no faith. The disassembly itself is neutral. A faith that cannot survive honest examination was not going to survive anyway.

****Deconversion**** is the conclusion that the faith is not true. It is not a process. It is a landing. A person can deconstruct without deconverting. A person can also, of course, deconstruct and then deconvert. But deconversion is a destination. Deconstruction is the road.

****Renovation**** is what I would prefer we call the healthy version. It is what happens when a believer discovers that the house they were living in had structural problems, tears out the bad framing, and rebuilds on the original foundation. The foundation is Christ. The framing was the cultural assumptions they thought were Christ. The house at the end of a renovation looks different from the house at the beginning. The ground underneath is the same.

The reason these three words matter is that churches keep treating deconstruction as if it were deconversion, and deconstructors keep treating deconversion as if it were renovation. Both are category errors. Both cost people who did not have to be lost.

A pastor I know, a good man, had a young woman in his church begin to ask hard questions. She was reading widely. She was bringing him material he had not encountered in seminary twenty years earlier. Her questions were not hostile. They were curious. He did what many pastors do. He told her she needed to be careful about what she was reading. He told her some of those authors had dangerous conclusions. He told her the questions she was asking often ended in people leaving the faith. He meant all of it as shepherding. She heard all of it as gatekeeping. Within a year she was gone. Not because of the books. Because of what the warning told her about the church. It told her the church was a place where serious questions were met with nervous containment. She decided she needed a place where she could think.

She was, at the moment the pastor warned her, not a deconverter. She was not even a renovator yet. She was a first-year deconstructor with her hand on the examination tools, doing the work the Bereans did. The pastor misread the phase. His misreading cost the church a member. It may yet cost more.

The opposite error is more common in the podcast ecosystem. A Christian begins to ask hard questions, finds a community of other people asking hard questions, and is told, explicitly or by the shape of the conversation, that the questions themselves are the point. That doubt is a virtue. That certainty is the enemy. That the faithful response to the hard question is to keep the question open forever. This is not deconstruction. It is a permanent scaffolding around a house that never gets rebuilt. The scaffolding becomes its own house. The house of scaffolding has no roof, and winter comes for everyone.

****The Berean.**** This person is doing the work Paul commended. They are testing what they were taught against Scripture. They are

reading primary sources. They are, often, more biblically literate than the leaders who are worried about them. They do not need to be warned. They need a pastor who can keep up with them. If their church cannot keep up, they will find a church that can, or they will find a library that can, and the library does not come with accountability.

****The Wounded.**** This person was hurt by the church. They were told purity was the measure of their worth, and they have now spent a decade disentangling their sexuality from their shame. They were in a youth group where the leader turned out to be a predator. They were in a family where the pastor defended the abuser. They were in a tradition that voted a particular way in a particular election and told them from the pulpit that voting any other way was sin, and when they watched the consequences of that vote unfold they watched the pulpit defend those consequences, and they could not do it anymore. The Wounded do not, in most cases, have a theological problem. They have an integrity problem. They watched the institution violate what it said it believed. They need to meet a version of the church that does not do that. Apologetics will not help them. Repentance will.

****The Drift.**** This person has gotten bored. Church went from a thing that made sense of their life to a thing that happened on Sunday mornings. The questions they are asking are not really questions. They are reasons. The reasons are scaffolding for a decision that was made six months ago in their stomach. They are going to leave. They already left. What they need is not answers. They need to be loved in a way that is not conditional on staying. They need to be reminded that the door is open going in both directions. Sometimes a Drift comes back. They usually come back when they realize that the world outside the church is not actually interested in their soul.

The categories are not rigid. A person can be a wounded Berean. A drift can become a wounded renovator after enough therapy. The categories are diagnostic tools, not cages. The point is that the response a person needs depends on which category they are in, and

the American church's default move is to treat every deconstructor as if they were a Drift who needs to be corralled or a Wounded person who needs to be told to forgive. The Berean gets treated like a Drift and leaves because nobody took them seriously. The Wounded gets treated like a Drift and leaves because nobody took their pain seriously. The Drift gets treated like a Berean, handed apologetics, and leaves because nobody saw what was actually going on.

Diagnosis matters. A cardiologist who treats every chest pain as reflux will eventually kill someone. A church that treats every deconstructor the same way is killing something too. It is killing its own future.

One more thing, before we move to what they are actually leaving.

Deconstruction is not primarily an intellectual event. That is the mistake the apologetics industry keeps making. It is treating deconstruction as if it were a debate, and the debate can be won with better arguments. But by the time most people are in deconstruction, the arguments have stopped doing the work the arguments were designed to do. This is not because the arguments are weak. It is because arguments do not repair trust, and the thing that has broken is trust.

When a child discovers that a parent lied about one important thing, the child does not begin with the question is the parent correct on other matters. The child begins with the question what else did you lie about. The child may still love the parent. The child may still live in the house. But the child is in a different relationship with the parent now. The parent cannot repair the relationship by providing a list of other things they did not lie about. The parent has to acknowledge the lie, own it, and let the child see what it costs to tell the truth. The relationship, if it rebuilds, rebuilds on something deeper than before. But it rebuilds slowly.

The American church told its children some things about Jesus, about Scripture, about holiness, about power, that do not hold up to examination. Some of what we told them is true and good and will

outlast every critic. Some of what we told them was cultural sediment we had mistaken for gospel. The children are old enough now to tell the difference. They are asking us to tell them which is which. A church that cannot answer that question is not going to keep its children, and a church that answers it defensively is going to keep fewer.

This book is an attempt to answer it honestly.

Turn the page. We are going to talk about what they are actually leaving.

CHAPTER 2

What They Are Really Leaving

Most deconstruction is not about Jesus. It is about the package Jesus was sold inside. If you want to understand why people are walking, you have to look at the package.

The pastor's first instinct, when someone he loves begins to deconstruct, is to defend the essentials. He will say the resurrection is true. He will say the Bible is true. He will say Jesus is Lord. He is not wrong about any of this. But he is answering questions the deconstructor has not yet asked. The deconstructor is not, in most cases, standing in front of the pastor to debate the resurrection. The deconstructor is standing in front of the pastor to ask whether the church that teaches the resurrection has become something Jesus himself would not recognize.

That is a different conversation. And the pastor who answers the first question when the second question is being asked will watch the deconstructor walk out the door wondering why the pastor could not hear what they were saying.

So let me name what is actually being said.

****The purity culture catastrophe.**** A generation of Christians, mostly but not only young women, were taught from the pulpit and the small group that their worth before God and before any future spouse was measured in whether they had kissed anyone, or held anyone's hand past a certain line, or thought about anyone in a way that crossed some unmarked threshold. They were told they were rose petals, and every touch was a petal lost, and by the time they were married there would be nothing left for the groom if they had not guarded the petals. They were told the way they dressed was a direct cause of other people's sin. They were handed rings and pledges at

thirteen and told the ring made them holy. Then they grew up. Some of them made it to marriage beds and could not function because their body had learned to associate desire with disgust. Some of them got divorced because the men they married, raised on the same material, could not function either. Some of them walked out of a marriage to a youth pastor who had groomed them at sixteen and found their church blame them for the groom. They read the Song of Songs in their thirties and realized their church had taught them the opposite of what the Bible actually teaches about sexuality. They looked at the ring. They looked at the scars. They left.

****The sexual abuse scandals.**** They kept coming. Catholic first, and then evangelical, and then denomination after denomination. The Houston Chronicle investigation into the Southern Baptist Convention. The Ravi Zacharias revelations. The Hillsong collapse. The Mars Hill documentary. The rolling list of pastors with hidden second lives and the elders who covered for them. It was not one story. It was a pattern. And the pattern had a shape that was hard to unsee once you saw it. The shape was this. The institution protects itself. When it has to choose between a victim and a celebrity, it chooses the celebrity. When it has to choose between transparency and the brand, it chooses the brand. When it has to choose between the abused and the donor, it chooses the donor. A generation watched this happen in slow motion, and they reasonably asked a question nobody wants to ask out loud. If the institution is this willing to protect itself at the cost of the vulnerable, why would we assume the institution is telling us the truth about God.

That question is the corrosive one. It is not a question about God. It is a question about the institution's reliability as a witness. And a witness whose reliability has collapsed cannot restore it by shouting louder about the message. It can only restore it by telling the truth about itself and paying the cost. Most institutions will not pay the cost. So they lose the witness.

****The political captivity of the American church.**** This is the one pastors hate most, so I will be careful with it, but I will not be

soft with it. There is a version of American Christianity that has become indistinguishable from a political tribe. It has a preferred party, a preferred leader, and a preferred set of enemies. It baptizes those preferences with language from the pulpit. It implies, and sometimes says openly, that a Christian who votes differently is not really a Christian. It reacts to public sin in its own political tribe with silence or excuse and to public sin in the other tribe with prophetic outrage. It has, for many watching, become impossible to distinguish from cable news with a cross on it.

I am a pastor. I vote. I have opinions about policy I could defend with Scripture and reason. I am not saying Christians should have no political views. I am saying this. When an entire generation of young people watched their parents' church endorse, defend, and excuse conduct from a politician that the same church would have disciplined a deacon for, they learned something. They learned that the church's professed ethics were not real ethics. They were tribal markers. The ethics bent when the tribe needed them to bend. A young person raised to take the sermons seriously will not take the sermons seriously again once they have seen this. They may keep attending for a while. They will not take the sermons seriously.

This is not a left-wing deconstruction point, by the way. There are progressive versions of the same captivity. There are progressive churches that have let their politics rewrite their theology exactly as thoroughly as conservative churches have. The captivity is the problem, not the direction. When politics becomes the lens through which Scripture is read, Scripture stops functioning as Scripture. It becomes a resource pool for the tribe. The tribe, not the risen Christ, becomes the actual authority. Young people can smell this a hundred yards away. They are leaving because they can smell it.

****The prosperity gospel and its softer cousins.**** The hard version of the prosperity gospel is obvious. Seed your faith, plant your money, claim your healing, buy the pastor a jet. Most people reading this book already see through it. The softer cousins are more dangerous because they are more plausible. They appear as the

preaching that treats Jesus primarily as a resource for your best life. They surface in the worship songs that sing about God as if he were a romantic partner whose job is to reassure you. They take the form of the ministry that measures its success by attendance and giving rather than by cruciformity. They come through as the assumption, pervasive and mostly unconscious, that faith is supposed to make your life work. When life does not work, the faith feels broken. When enough life does not work, the faith feels like a lie.

The people who are walking have, many of them, hit a wall life was not supposed to contain. A miscarriage. A divorce they did not want. A child with a diagnosis. A cancer that does not respond. They have turned to a faith they were told would work and discovered that the version of the faith they were given does not have a theology for the wall. The New Testament does. Paul wrote Philippians from prison, and the theme of the letter is joy. James opened his letter telling believers to count it all joy when they encountered trials of various kinds. Job sat on the ash heap and refused to curse God and was declared righteous. The Christian faith has an enormous theology of suffering. The American church has mostly replaced it with a theology of breakthrough. The wall meets the breakthrough theology and the breakthrough theology shatters. The person thinks Christianity has failed. What has failed is a sub-Christian substitute.

****The domestication of Jesus.**** This one is subtle, and it runs underneath the others. At some point, the Jesus who flipped tables in the temple, called the religious experts white-washed tombs, stood in front of a hostile crowd and called out their hypocrisy, cried over the city that had killed its prophets, and went willingly to a Roman cross at the hands of the cooperative religious establishment of his day, became, in the American imagination, a friendly spiritual life coach who mostly wants us to be nice. The Sermon on the Mount was reread as personal wisdom rather than kingdom ethics. The parables were flattened into moral stories rather than kingdom subversions. The miracles were reinterpreted as personal demonstrations rather than signs of a new world breaking in. The resurrection was treated

as a ticket to heaven rather than the beginning of a new creation.

The result is a Jesus who fits in the living room. He does not threaten anybody. He does not ask anything that costs the middle class anything. He does not stand on the side of the poor in any way that would embarrass a donor. He is a Jesus who can be endorsed by a candidate, printed on a coffee mug, and quoted on the back of a merchandise tee. He is not the Jesus of the Gospels. Young people are leaving the domesticated Jesus because once you read the Gospels you cannot unsee the gap.

****The biblical illiteracy dressed as biblical faithfulness.**** A movement that loves the Bible and does not read it is a movement in trouble. Across the American church, at levels ranging from the pew to the pulpit, the Bible is cited constantly and engaged rarely. A person can attend an evangelical church for twenty years and have never worked through a book of the Bible slowly, in context, with the actual flow of the argument intact. They hear verses. They do not read books. They memorize proof-texts for positions. They do not sit inside the text long enough for it to reshape the positions.

The young people who are asking hard questions have, in many cases, started reading the Bible for themselves. They have discovered that what the book actually says is stranger, stronger, and more disruptive than what the church taught them it said. They have discovered that the proof-texts were often ripped out of contexts that say almost the opposite. They have discovered that the verses they were told were obvious are, when read slowly, deeply contested. They have discovered, in short, that the people who told them the Bible clearly says this or that had not read the surrounding chapters recently, or had never read them at all, and were repeating a tradition dressed as an exegesis.

This is catastrophic. It means the church lost authority the moment the reader caught up. And the readers have caught up.

****The church's response to the critics.**** And finally, the thing that turns deconstructing believers into departing ones more than any

single item on the list. When they raise any of these concerns, they are met with defensiveness, not repentance. They are told they are being divisive. They are told they are a threat. They are told they have drifted into worldly categories. They are told their generation is characterized by doubt. They are told they need to submit more and think less. The institution circles the wagons.

This is, for the Berean and the Wounded, the final signal. The institution cannot self-correct. The institution has tied its identity to its own infallibility. A person cannot grow inside an institution that cannot be wrong. So they leave.

That is the list. I have no interest in softening any of it. All of it is real. All of it is happening. A church that wants to respond has to start by acknowledging that the critique is not coming primarily from faithlessness. It is coming from the uncomfortable fact that the critics have, on most of the items above, read the Bible more carefully than the institution they are critiquing. That is hard to accept. Accepting it is where any honest response has to start.

Before we go to the next chapter, I want to make a confession, because I meant what I said in the introduction about self-implication.

I have, from the pulpit, at times over the last fifteen years, defended positions I would not defend now. I have, at times, answered a deconstructor's question with a version of defensiveness that I now recognize was about protecting the institution and not about shepherding the soul. I have been, at moments, part of the problem I am naming. I am still figuring out what repentance looks like for a pastor in my position. I do not get to stand above this list. Nobody in American ministry does.

If you are reading this as a deconstructor, know that at least one pastor in Michigan is aware that the list is real, and is trying to do something about it. If you are reading this as a pastor, welcome to the discomfort. The next chapter is about why we keep missing what is actually being said, and how to stop.

CHAPTER 3

Why the Church Keeps Missing It

There is a particular kind of conversation that happens between a pastor and a deconstructor, and if you have been a pastor long enough you have been in it. It goes something like this.

The deconstructor says something honest. The pastor hears something threatening. The pastor responds to the thing he heard. The deconstructor hears a pastor who did not hear them. The deconstructor says it again, louder. The pastor, still hearing threat, responds with more force. The deconstructor leaves. The pastor tells the elders the person was not really open to correction. The elders nod. The next deconstructor walks in and the cycle repeats.

I have been on both sides of this conversation. I have been the pastor who missed what was being said. I have also, in my own earlier crises of faith, been the person who walked out of a pastor's office because the pastor was answering somebody else.

This chapter is about why the miss keeps happening, and how to stop. It is aimed at pastors, but anyone who loves a deconstructor needs it. The parents of deconstructing adult children make the same mistakes the pastors make, usually for the same reasons. The mistakes are not about stupidity. They are about reflex. The reflex is the thing to examine.

****The defensive crouch.**** The first reflex is to defend. When somebody criticizes the church, the pastor's trained response, honed over a decade of culture-war formation, is to explain why the criticism is not fair. This is sometimes the right move. It is almost never the first move. What the deconstructor is offering, in many cases, is not a debate but a grief. They are grieving the loss of a simpler faith. They are grieving the discovery that something they

trusted was not trustworthy. A pastor who rushes to defend the institution is a pastor who has refused to grieve with them. That refusal is a choice, and the person making it is reading it correctly. If the pastor cannot grieve, the pastor is with the institution, not with the sheep.

The pastoral move is to grieve first. The defense, if it is warranted, can come later, in a different conversation, when trust has been re-established. But the grief cannot be skipped. When Jesus stood over Jerusalem and wept, he was not defending the temple. He was mourning the city. A pastor who cannot mourn the American church cannot be trusted to speak truthfully about it.

****The tribal reflex.**** The second reflex is to identify the deconstructor with an enemy tribe. The critic who complains about political captivity is a liberal. The critic who complains about purity culture is a progressive. The critic who complains about abuse scandals has been listening to the wrong podcasts. Each of these moves takes the concrete pain in front of the pastor and turns it into a slot in the culture war. Once it is in the slot, the pastor knows what to do with it. The culture war has scripts. The scripts are easier than the person.

The problem is that the slot is almost always wrong. Real deconstructors do not map cleanly to political tribes. A young woman wounded by purity culture may be more theologically conservative than her pastor. A young man grieving the abuse scandals may have no progressive politics at all. A young mother who watched her church rally around a particular candidate may be a confessional Christian who happens to have noticed her tradition got used as a mascot. The slot is false. When you put the person in the slot, you have stopped seeing the person.

The discipline is to listen long enough to discover that the person in front of you is not the caricature in your head. It takes more time than the five-minute conversation at the coffee table after the service allows. You will have to schedule the coffee. You will have to drink it

slowly. You will have to ask at least three follow-up questions before you say anything declarative. If you cannot do that, you are going to lose them, and they will be right to go, because a shepherd who will not look at a sheep long enough to recognize it is not shepherding anything.

****Answering the question that was not asked.**** The third reflex is the apologetics reflex. The pastor is trained to have answers. When a question comes, the pastor produces an answer. The answer is aimed, usually, at the question the apologetics textbook anticipated. The apologetics textbook was written for the skeptic in the debate room. The deconstructor is not in the debate room. The deconstructor is in an existential crisis that occasionally takes the form of a question that resembles something from the debate room.

So the question sounds like this. Are the Gospels historically reliable. The pastor has the answer. He talks about the early manuscripts and the multiple independent attestations and the criterion of embarrassment. All of his answer is correct. None of his answer is relevant. The question underneath the question was not about historicity. The question was whether the pastor could be trusted to tell the truth about what the Gospels actually say, given that the same pastor had, six months earlier, used a Gospel text to defend something the deconstructor now believes is indefensible. The real question was not is it real. The real question was can you be trusted to read it honestly. The answer to that question is not in the apologetics textbook.

The discipline, for the pastor, is to learn to ask what is the question underneath the question. You will usually find out by asking. You can ask it directly. What are you most afraid of in this. What would it mean if what you are afraid of were true. What has made you ask this now. The questions are not complicated. The humility to ask them is.

****The solution sermon.**** The fourth reflex is to try to fix the deconstructor. The pastor reaches for the sermon he would preach if

he had thirty minutes. He delivers a compressed version at the coffee table. He thinks he is being helpful. The deconstructor is not in the market for a sermon. They have had sermons. They came to the coffee table because the sermons stopped landing, and they wanted to be with a human being who could set the sermon down.

A compressed sermon at the coffee table is the pastoral equivalent of handing a grieving widow a pamphlet on the stages of grief. The pamphlet might have accurate information. It is the wrong thing in that moment. What she needs is somebody to sit down and not talk for a minute. What the deconstructor needs is, in most cases, the same thing. They need a person who can be with them without needing to produce something. Presence has to come before solution. The order matters.

The test, for the pastor, is simple. Can you have a thirty-minute conversation with a deconstructor in which you never tell them anything. You only ask questions. You reflect back what they said. You acknowledge the parts that are true. You stay with the parts that are hard. At the end of thirty minutes, they should feel more heard than any previous conversation on this topic in their life. If you cannot pass that test, the deconstructor is not going to come back, and the fault is yours.

****The slippery slope panic.**** The fifth reflex is fear. The pastor sees a person begin to ask serious questions and projects forward to the worst-case version of where those questions might go. Once the worst case is in his head, every conversation is actually with the worst case, not the person. He warns the person away from books the person has already read. He implies the direction they are heading leads to apostasy. He mentions, in a tone that is meant to be gentle but is not, that he has seen this go badly before.

The person hears, accurately, that the pastor is afraid of them. Once they hear the fear, they know the pastor is not a person they can be honest with. They begin to protect the pastor from their real questions. They give the pastor the sanitized version. The pastor feels

reassured, because the sanitized version is manageable. The relationship, meanwhile, has become a performance. The person is doing their real thinking somewhere else. That somewhere else may or may not have their soul's best interest in mind. The pastor has effectively driven them into less trustworthy company by being unable to bear the real questions himself.

The discipline is to train yourself to stay in the room with the worst version of the question. If a person says to you, I am not sure I believe the resurrection anymore, you have to be able to say tell me more without flinching. You have to believe, deep in your bones, that the resurrection is strong enough to survive being examined out loud. If you do not believe that, the problem is not the deconstructor. The problem is your own faith. Repair that before you try to repair theirs.

****The tribal shame response.**** The sixth reflex is the one I hate the most because I have done it and seen it done. When a person's deconstruction becomes public, or becomes known in the church, the community's reflex is to treat them as if they are contagious. Other members are warned to be careful around them. Conversations at small group become stilted. The deconstructor notices. They always notice. They experience it as social exile, because that is what it is. They leave, and the leaving is attributed to their unbelief, when in fact the leaving was catalyzed by a community that treated questions as a threat to be contained rather than a soul to be carried.

The early church had a different posture. Thomas doubted the resurrection publicly. Jesus appeared a week later and offered his wounds for inspection. Jesus did not shame Thomas. He did not exile Thomas. He did not warn the other disciples about Thomas. He gave Thomas access to the evidence and trusted the evidence to do its work. Thomas came through. If Jesus could bear Thomas, your small group can bear the young mom with hard questions.

The reason it is so hard is that it costs something. It costs the pastor his certainty that he is automatically in the right. It costs the community its sense that its boundaries are clean. It costs the

institution the comfort of not having to examine itself. All of those costs are worth paying, because the alternative is losing people you did not have to lose.

I want to end this chapter with a scene. It is from my own ministry. I will not give you the details, because the person it concerns deserves her privacy. But I will give you the shape.

A few years ago, a woman in my church came to tell me she was done. She had a list of reasons. Some of the reasons were things I agreed with. Some were things I did not. I had spent the week before preparing a careful response in case she asked for one. I had arguments ready. I had verses ready. I had a pastoral plan.

She sat down and told me her reasons, and in the middle of them she started to cry. Not performatively. Not strategically. She cried the way a person cries when they have been holding something for a long time and finally let it go.

I set down the plan. I did not deliver any of the arguments. I said the only true thing I had to say, which was I am so sorry. Then I said I should have seen this sooner. Then I did not say anything else for a while. She cried for another ten minutes. Then she said thank you. Then she said she needed some time. Then she left.

She came back. Not right away. Six months later, she was back on Sunday mornings, sitting in a different seat than she used to. She has never been exactly the same. But she is there, and she reads the Bible now more carefully than I do, and her questions are sharper than they were, and her faith, I think, is stronger than it has ever been. Nothing about that outcome was my doing. What I did was, in the right moment, shut up. If I had done what my first three reflexes told me to do, I would have lost her.

Most deconstruction conversations will not go that well. Some people will leave and not come back. That is not the pastor's fault, and the pastor should not carry it as if it were.

The rest of this book is going to get inside what they have been

reading, what they have been finding, and what faithfulness looks like when it is not wearing the costume.

CHAPTER 4

The Bible the Critics Found

There is a version of the Bible you were given in Sunday school. There is a version of the Bible atheists describe on YouTube. Neither of them is quite the Bible. The actual book is stranger, older, and more disruptive than either party wants to admit, and a person in deconstruction, picking it up honestly, is in a fair fight with it for the first time. That fair fight is where this chapter lives.

I am going to walk through the hardest places the critics have found, and I am going to tell you the truth about each one. Some of the critics' points are good, and the church has not answered them well. Some of their points dissolve the moment you stop reading the Bible with the assumptions of a twenty-first century American and start reading it with the assumptions of the people who wrote it. Either way, you have to do the reading. There is no shortcut. The good news, which will not feel like good news until you are on the other side, is that the Bible can take the pressure. What has failed the tests is not the text. It is the packaging.

****The manuscripts.**** The critic says the Bible has been copied so many times we do not know what it originally said. This is the version of the argument that filled my YouTube feed at sixteen, when I was still an atheist, and it felt devastating. It is, on closer inspection, the weakest argument in the skeptic's arsenal. The New Testament is by orders of magnitude the best-attested document of the ancient world. We have earlier manuscripts, more manuscripts, and more geographically distributed manuscripts of the New Testament than of any comparable ancient text. Where there are variants, and there are many, the overwhelming majority are spelling differences, word order changes, and scribal adjustments that do not affect meaning. The places where a variant actually bears on doctrine are countable on

two hands, and even there, the doctrine in question is defended from dozens of other texts. The manuscript argument is a bogeyman. A sixty-minute honest look at the data ends it.

The Old Testament is a different story, a more interesting one. The Dead Sea Scrolls showed us a Hebrew Bible text that was, with minor variation, the same Hebrew Bible we have now, a thousand years older than our previous copies. That is a stunning vindication of textual stability. But it also showed us, in places, different textual traditions coexisting in the same period, with slightly different readings. That reality is actually represented in our English Bibles if you pay attention to the footnotes. The footnotes are the argument. The text is transparent about its own history. That transparency, to a person trained to expect the Bible to hide, is the first surprise of honest engagement.

****The canon.**** The critic says the Bible was decided by a council of politically motivated men who picked winners and excluded losers. The popular version of this is Dan Brown. The scholarly version is more sophisticated and more wrong. There was never a moment at which a committee sat down with a pile of equally authoritative documents and voted on which to include. The four Gospels were recognized as authoritative across the church within a century of Jesus, because of their apostolic connections and because the church that received them recognized their voice. The alleged alternative Gospels, when you read them, make the case for the canon by themselves. The Gospel of Thomas is a collection of sayings, some close to the canonical Gospels and some wildly divergent, with no coherent narrative or moral architecture. The Gospel of Peter has a talking cross. These are not suppressed truths. They are, on inspection, transparently later and transparently derivative.

What the church actually did with the canon is what a family does with photographs. Not every picture taken of a grandmother goes in the family album. The ones that go in are the ones the family recognizes. The ones that do not are not suppressed. They are not claimed. The authoritative claim is communal and retrospective, and

it is made by the people who know the face.

****The violence.**** This is harder. The critic points at the conquest of Canaan and asks how a loving God could command the slaughter of entire populations. The easy answers you were taught in youth group are not sufficient. It will not do to say they were all wicked and deserved it, because the text includes infants. It will not do to say it was a different dispensation, because a God who changed his ethics cannot be trusted on his current ones. The question is real and it deserves real engagement.

Here is what a careful reading of the text actually shows. The conquest narratives are, first, written in the language of the ancient Near East, where hyperbole in war reporting is a standard literary convention. A king would say he utterly destroyed a city and then, three chapters later, describe capturing the same city again. The ancient reader knew the convention and knew how to read it. The modern reader, untrained in the genre, reads it flat and recoils. Second, the texts themselves are clear that the Canaanites had been given time to repent. Genesis 15 says the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete. It will not be complete for four hundred years. The judgment was not arbitrary. It was the end of a long patience. Third, the very same moral standard that brings judgment on the Canaanites brings judgment on Israel a few centuries later when Israel becomes Canaanite in its behavior. The God of the Old Testament is not a tribal deity who favors his people and smites everyone else. He is the moral judge of all nations, beginning with his own.

None of this removes the difficulty. The text is hard. It is supposed to be hard. But the critic who treats the violence passages as proof that the biblical God is a monster has not wrestled with the text. They have skimmed it looking for ammunition. The Christian who has read Walter Moberly or Paul Copan or Greg Boyd, even when they disagree on the details, knows there is a conversation going on that is not being represented in the YouTube caricature. The critic's argument lands with force only against a version of the Bible the serious readers gave up on a long time ago.

****The contradictions.**** The critic lists alleged contradictions. The Gospels give different numbers of angels at the tomb. The crucifixion accounts place the event on different days. Paul's Damascus road story is told three times in Acts with different details. Each of these is either an apparent discrepancy that dissolves on closer reading or a real variation that reflects the character of eyewitness testimony. Real witnesses of real events do not give identical accounts. They give overlapping, differently-angled accounts that agree on the load-bearing facts and differ on the details. Four videos of the same car accident do not match frame for frame. They do show, on inspection, the same car accident. The Gospels, read as what they are, function as four overlapping testimonies to the same life. The differences are marks of authenticity, not forgery. Forgers align details. Witnesses do not.

****The problem passages on sexuality and gender.**** This is where many deconstructors are most concerned, and this is where I will point you to the separate book on the question that I have already written and will not duplicate here. I will say only this. The texts say what they say. The historic church read them the way it did because that is what they say. The revisionist readings, charitable as some of them are, require theological moves that, if applied consistently, dissolve the authority of Scripture itself, because the method that lets you rescue those texts can be used to rescue any text from any claim. The question for the deconstructor on this subject is not is the traditional reading cruel. It is is the text actually saying what the traditional reading has said it is saying. Spoiler. In most cases it is. The pastoral response has often been cruel. That is a separate failure, and it is serious. But the text is not on the revisionist's side. I know that is uncomfortable to read. I did not write it to be comfortable.

****The authorship questions.**** The critic says Moses did not write the Pentateuch, that the Gospels were written decades after Jesus by people who never met him, that many of Paul's letters were forged under his name. Each of these claims has a kernel of real scholarship behind it and a mountain of overclaim on top. The

Pentateuch is clearly edited. That is visible in the text itself. It does not follow that the edited text is unreliable. The Gospels were written within a generation of the events, by or in connection with the eyewitnesses, in a culture where oral transmission was astonishingly stable. That they were written down after the fact is not a problem. It is the norm for ancient history. The disputed Pauline letters are, in the judgment of many serious scholars, genuinely Pauline, and the arguments against them rest on stylistic assumptions that do not bear the weight placed on them. The critic has, in many cases, accepted the most skeptical version of critical scholarship as if it were settled fact, when the actual scholarly situation is far more contested. A believer who has read Richard Bauckham on eyewitness testimony knows the other side of this argument is not being represented. Bauckham is not fringe. He is Cambridge. The one-sided reading the critic inherited is itself a form of indoctrination.

****The load-bearing Greek.**** Let me give you one example of what I mean by the way a Greek word actually changes the argument. It will stand in for a dozen examples the deconstructor may encounter. The word **metanoia** is usually translated repentance. Most people hear repentance and think of guilt, or contrition, or groveling. The word does not mean that. It is a compound. **Meta** is a preposition that means after, or across, or with. **Noia** is from **nous**, mind. **Metanoia** means something like a change of mind across time, a reorientation of the whole thinking self. It has nothing to do, etymologically, with feeling bad. Jesus did not stand by the Jordan and tell people to feel worse. He told them the kingdom of God was at hand and their minds needed to rearrange. That is a different gospel call than a lot of American preaching has delivered. A deconstructor who has been told that Christian faith is about feeling adequately guilty is meeting a different Christian faith when they meet the actual word. They are meeting a faith that asks for a reorientation of the whole mental architecture. That is harder than feeling bad. It is also much more freeing.

There is more. There is always more. The point is not to produce

an apologetic tract that answers every question. The point is to name what is true. Which is this. The Bible the critics have found is, in places, genuinely strange, genuinely hard, and genuinely different from what American Christianity has preached. It is also, on careful reading, genuinely what it claims to be. A text that bears the weight of examination. A text that pushes back on every attempt to conscript it into a human agenda, left or right, ancient or modern. A text that still, after four thousand years of readers trying to domesticate it, refuses to be domesticated.

The faithful response to the Bible the critics found is not defense. It is deeper reading. The Bereans did not defend Paul. They examined what Paul said against Scripture. We are being asked to do the same thing with our inheritance. If our inheritance survives the examination, it survives stronger. If parts of our inheritance are sediment rather than gold, we should let it go. The gold is heavier anyway.

The Jesus under the brand is the next thing we have to find. He has been under there the whole time. Go to the next chapter and meet him.

CHAPTER 5

The Jesus Who Was Buried Under the Brand

Read the Gospels for a month. Just the Gospels. Do not read any commentary. Do not listen to any sermons. Read Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John straight through, slowly, as if you had never heard the story before. At the end of the month, ask yourself whether the person in those books is the same person you have heard preached about most of your life.

For most American Christians who have done this experiment honestly, the answer is no.

The Jesus of the Gospels is not rude for the sake of being rude, but he is not smooth. He is confrontational with the religious professionals and tender with prostitutes and tax collectors. He breaks the Sabbath protocols that the religious experts of his day considered load-bearing. He eats with the wrong people on purpose, and often. He refuses to answer direct questions with direct answers when the question is a trap. He tells stories that end in ways the listeners do not expect and walks away without explaining them. He cries in public. He loses his temper in the temple and flips the tables of the merchants because the house of prayer has been made a den of robbers. He says things in private to his disciples that they do not understand until years later. He dies on purpose and tells them in advance he is going to.

He is not the Jesus on the coffee mug.

I want to be careful here. I am not saying the friendly Jesus is wrong. Jesus did welcome little children. He did feed crowds. He did forgive sinners. The gentleness is not invented. The gentleness is real.

The problem is not that the American church invented the gentleness. The problem is that it amputated everything else and kept the gentleness as the whole. A Jesus who is only gentle is a Jesus who would never have been crucified. The crucifixion requires a Jesus who threatened enough powerful people with something real for them to decide to kill him. That Jesus is not on the coffee mug. He got edited out.

****The Jesus who refuses the crowd.**** John 6 is one of the most telling chapters in the Gospels. Jesus feeds the five thousand. The crowd gets excited. They try to make him king by force. He withdraws. The next day, when they find him again, he preaches a sermon that is designed to thin them out. He tells them they have to eat his flesh and drink his blood, and the text tells us that at the end of it, many of his disciples turned back and no longer walked with him. This is not a marketing strategy. This is not a megachurch playbook. This is a prophet refusing to let the crowd's enthusiasm rewrite his message. The American church, which measures success by attendance, does not know what to do with this Jesus. It has quietly removed him.

****The Jesus who indicts the religious establishment.**** Read Matthew 23. Read it out loud. Listen to the rhythm of it. Woe to you scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites. Seven times. You shut the kingdom of heaven in people's faces. You cross sea and land to make a single convert, and when he becomes one, you make him twice as much a child of hell as yourselves. You tithe mint and dill and cumin and have neglected the weightier matters of the law, justice and mercy and faithfulness. You are like whitewashed tombs, outwardly beautiful, but inside full of dead people's bones. This is the Jesus the domestication has removed. This is the Jesus who would not fit easily behind the pulpit of many of the churches that claim his name. He would be, to many of them, the pulpit guest the elder board would gently advise not to invite back.

****The Jesus who stands with the margins.**** He touches lepers, which the law said would defile him, and instead of defiling him the

touch heals the leper. He talks with a Samaritan woman at a well in broad daylight, which no respectable rabbi would have done. He receives a woman who was caught in adultery and refuses to let her accusers execute her, and he also tells her to go and sin no more. Both halves are him. The mercy and the moral clarity are not in tension. They are the same love speaking in two directions.

The American church has tended to pick one half. Progressive versions keep the mercy and drop the moral clarity. Conservative versions keep the moral clarity and drop the mercy, or keep a performance of mercy that disappears the moment it would cost the community anything. Neither version is Jesus. Jesus is both, always, at the same time, and he is not embarrassed by either.

****The Jesus who tells parables designed to confuse.**** The parable of the prodigal son is not primarily about the prodigal son. It is about the older brother. The punchline is not the party. The punchline is the father leaving the party to go plead with the son who stayed and resented everyone who came back. Jesus told that parable to Pharisees, not to prodigals. The domesticated reading has the Pharisees cheering for the welcome of the prodigal, when the actual parable is aimed at their chest. They are the older brother. Jesus is telling them they are the ones who will not come in to the party.

When you read the parables as they were delivered, to the actual audiences who first heard them, you discover that most of them are not cozy moral stories. They are kingdom landmines. The good Samaritan is a story told to a lawyer who wanted to know who his neighbor was, and the answer is your ethnic enemy is your neighbor, and you are no better than the priest and the Levite if you refuse to act on that. The workers in the vineyard is a story about grace that offends the workers who have been there the longest, because grace does offend the long-faithful when they realize grace means the latecomer gets the same thing they do.

Each of these, domesticated, becomes a vague lesson about being kind. Undomesticated, each of them is a trap set for a particular kind

of hearer, and the hearer is usually the one sitting in the front pew of your Sunday service. Including the one in the pulpit.

****The Jesus who cries.**** John 11. The shortest verse in English Bibles. Jesus wept. Lazarus is dead. Jesus knows he is about to raise him. The tears are not a performance. They are not practice grief. They are the grief of God at a world that has a word like dead in it. Jesus cries because his friend is dead and because his friends are heartbroken and because death itself is an enemy, and he hates it, and he is about to fight it, and he will win this round and lose the next one and win the one after that for everyone who has ever lived. The tears are real. They are not subordinated to the miracle. The miracle is not the reason the tears are valid. The tears are valid because grief is valid. God himself is saying so.

This is not the Jesus who tells you to count your blessings. This is the Jesus who will weep with you over a miscarriage and hold your hand through the chemotherapy and be present at your grandmother's funeral, and the presence will not erase the loss, it will refuse to let the loss have the last word. The American church has sometimes been so afraid of grief it has told its members not to feel it. It was not in the Bible. It was in the culture that had colonized the Bible.

****The Jesus who dies on purpose.**** The crucifixion, in the Gospels, is not an accident. It is not something that happened to Jesus. Luke 9:51 says as the days drew near for him to be taken up, he set his face to go to Jerusalem. He walks into the trap with his eyes open. He tells the disciples in advance what is going to happen. He prays at Gethsemane, not to escape the cross, but for the strength to go through it. He goes silent in front of Pilate because there is nothing left to say to a man who has already been convicted by his own cowardice. And then he dies, slowly, in public, for people who had cheered for his death a few days earlier and for people who were not yet born and for people reading this book.

The atonement is not a transaction between Jesus and an angry Father who needed blood. That caricature has done enormous

damage. The atonement is Jesus, who is God in the flesh, absorbing into himself the full weight of what has gone wrong between God and human beings, and bearing it until it breaks. It is the triune God doing in himself what no human being could do. It is the love of God showing up at the worst address in human history, which is the cross, and refusing to leave until the worst thing has been defeated. It is not a trick. It is not a loophole. It is the thing the whole Bible has been pointing at from Genesis 3 forward. If you have lost belief in the atonement, it is worth asking whether you lost belief in the real one or in a caricature that was never the thing.

****The Jesus who rose.**** The resurrection is the turning point of everything. Without it, the Christian faith is a touching ethical tradition with an inspiring founder, no more authoritative than any other. With it, everything else follows. The earliest Christians did not say Jesus rose from the dead as a metaphor. They said it as a historical claim that they had eaten fish with him. They died for that claim. Not for the ethics. Not for the community. For the claim that a particular man had walked out of a particular tomb on a particular morning, and they had seen him.

The deconstructor has to do something with the resurrection. They can deny it, in which case Christianity is false and all the hard work of reforming it is wasted, because you cannot reform what is not true. They can accept it, in which case everything else is downstream of that, and a church that abuses or misreads the implications is still accountable to the man who walked out of the tomb. There is no third option where the resurrection is vaguely inspiring but not historical and the rest of the faith goes on as a culturally valuable tradition. Paul closed that door in 1 Corinthians 15. If Christ has not been raised, he said, our preaching is useless and so is your faith. We are then found to be false witnesses about God. Paul did not believe the faith could survive without the resurrection. Neither should we.

Here is what I want you to hear at the end of this chapter.

The Jesus of the Gospels is worth following, and the Jesus of the Gospels has been covered over in American Christianity by a Jesus who is more comfortable to market. If you have lost faith in the marketed Jesus, that may be exactly the loss that lets you find the other one. A deconstruction that strips the paint off and reveals the original wood is not a loss of faith. It is a restoration. You may find that what is under the paint is stranger and stronger than you were told. You may find that the Jesus who wept at Lazarus's tomb and drove out the moneychangers and ate with Matthew and walked toward Jerusalem with his face set is a person you could love, even now, at the end of a long disillusionment. He has been waiting for you to find him. He is not nervous about your doubts. He has seen worse.

The next chapter is about the history you were not taught. The church has done terrible things and faithful things, and the faithful version of Christian history is stronger than the sanitized version the critics think we are hiding.

CHAPTER 6

The History the Youth Group Did Not Teach

There is a version of church history that most American Christians received in small pieces, in high school or college, usually in the mouth of a critic. It goes like this. The church invented itself at Nicaea as a political tool of the Roman Empire. It burned witches. It ran the Inquisition. It blessed the crusades. It protected slavery. It fought against science. It did some good charity work here and there, mostly as a cover for the rest of it. And here we are today.

This version is not nothing. Each of the items in it has some truth at its core. The problem is that it is the whole story told as if it were the whole story, when in fact it is the scandal reel of two thousand years. A church lived every single day of those two thousand years, and most of what happened in those days is not in the scandal reel. The scandal reel is accurate. It is also a small fraction of the footage. The person who only watches the scandal reel thinks they have watched the movie. They have not.

I am going to give you a more honest version of the history. It is not going to be a defense, because the sins are real and they matter. It is going to be the whole thing, as nearly as I can fit it in a chapter, because the whole thing is stronger than the edited version. Tom Holland, who is not a Christian, wrote a seven-hundred page book called **Dominion** making a case most Christian historians have been making for a long time and most American Christians have never heard. The case is that the moral assumptions the modern Western world treats as universal and obvious are not universal and obvious. They are Christian, and they were not common in the ancient world before Christianity, and they would not survive the

death of Christian culture. The critics who are using those assumptions to indict Christianity are standing on a moral platform that Christianity built.

That is not an argument for Christianity being right. It is an argument for being fair to the record. The record includes the crusades. It also includes the hospitals. You do not get one without the other.

****The early church.**** Start here, because this is the period the critic thinks was either a purer time the later church betrayed or a mess the later church invented. Neither is true. The early church, in the first three centuries before it had any political power, was a mostly urban, mostly poor, mostly mixed movement of Jews and Gentiles who met in houses, shared food across social boundaries the Roman world considered scandalous, cared for the plague-sick when everyone else fled the cities, refused to expose unwanted infants when the Roman world did so routinely, and raised the status of women, slaves, and children by slow insistence on the image of God in every human being. They were periodically martyred for refusing to worship the emperor. They prayed for the emperor anyway. They wrote letters to each other across the Mediterranean and worked out, slowly, what it meant that the man they worshipped had been a carpenter executed by the state and was still alive. Nicaea in 325 did not invent their theology. It formalized what the martyrs had already been dying for. That is a defensible claim, and the historical record supports it.

****The imperial church.**** When Constantine converted and Christianity became a permitted and then privileged religion, something shifted, and the shift has been the source of centuries of argument. Some of it was good. The persecution stopped. The church could build openly. The emperor could be held accountable by ecclesial voices, at least in theory, in a way no one had been able to hold the emperor accountable before. Ambrose standing up to Theodosius was a kind of moral weight that had not existed. Some of it was disastrous. The church took on the instruments of the state. It

started using coercive power to enforce belief. It began to measure itself by size and influence rather than by cruciformity. The Constantinian shift, as historians call it, is not one thing. It is a long entanglement whose pros and cons are still being sorted.

The honest Christian does not have to defend every imperial move the church made. Augustine made arguments for coercing the Donatists that most Christians today, rightly, would reject. That does not mean Augustine should be discarded. It means Augustine was a man writing inside a particular political moment, and we can honor his best work and refuse his worst. Every great thinker requires that kind of reading. The critics who treat every historical Christian failure as proof the tradition is worthless are applying a standard they would not apply to any other tradition. They would not cancel the Enlightenment because Voltaire was an antisemite. They would not cancel classical Greek philosophy because Aristotle defended slavery. Hold the same standard. Or do not. But do not weaponize the standard in one direction only.

****The medieval period.**** The period the critic mentions most often is the one they know least well. Yes, there were crusades. The crusades were not a monolithic event. They were a complex, multi-century series of military campaigns with a mix of motivations, some genuinely religious, some political, some economic, and some plainly sinful. Some of them were defensive responses to real aggression. Some of them were offensive, and some of the offensive ones committed atrocities that contemporary Christians condemned at the time. The sack of Constantinople by crusaders against other Christians in 1204 was widely denounced by the papacy, for example. The full story is uglier in places than the critic knows and more complex in others than the defender knows.

The medieval church also built the universities that eventually produced the scientists the critic celebrates. It preserved classical texts through the fall of Rome. It produced theologians like Thomas Aquinas, whose ability to hold together faith and reason has not been improved upon in eight hundred years. It produced Francis of Assisi,

whose poverty and gentleness shaped the moral imagination of a continent. It produced hospitals, the idea of international law, the first serious attempts at a theory of legitimate warfare, the refuge of monasteries where women could read and write and govern themselves in ways unavailable in most secular life. The critic who takes the crusades and leaves the rest is not reading the period. They are scoring a point.

****The Reformation.**** This one matters more to American Christians because most of us, whether we know it or not, are its inheritors. The Reformation was not simple. It was a multi-generational fracturing of the Western church driven by a mix of genuine theological renewal, real ecclesial corruption, emerging national politics, new communications technology in the printing press, and several strong personalities who did not always like each other. Luther's convictions about justification by grace through faith were a recovery of something that had been obscured, and the recovery has been life-giving for half a billion believers. Luther's later writings on the Jews were a moral catastrophe that later contributed to real evil. Both are Luther.

The wars of religion that followed the Reformation killed a great many people. They also clarified, eventually, that coercion in matters of conscience was not a path the church could keep walking. The principle of religious freedom, which the secular critic usually attributes to the Enlightenment, was hammered out in significant part by Christians sickened by what had happened when Christians tried to force each other's consciences. Roger Williams founded Rhode Island as a religious liberty project. William Penn did the same with Pennsylvania. These were Christian projects grounded in Christian conviction that eventually became the ground for the secular critic's freedom to critique.

****The question of slavery.**** This is the hardest one, and I am not going to soften it. Christians defended slavery in the American South using the Bible. That defense is not a minor footnote. It was a large, sophisticated, well-resourced theological project that included

seminary professors and denominational statements and widely-distributed pamphlets. It was wrong. It was a spectacular failure of exegesis in service of an economic and cultural interest that the exegetes refused to examine. The abolitionists, many of whom were also Christians, read the same Bible and reached the opposite conclusion, and they were right.

The fact that the wrong side lost the historical argument does not wipe out the damage. Black Americans whose ancestors were enslaved are not required to be impressed that the abolitionists won the argument eventually. The church's role in slavery is a wound that the American church has still not fully reckoned with. A deconstructor who is leaving over the race question is seeing a real failure. The right response from the church is not to point at Wilberforce and call it a day. The right response is to examine, repent, and make restitution in whatever specific forms the specific situation requires. The church has begun doing this in some places. It has a long way to go.

But here is the thing the critic misses. The framework that eventually defeated slavery was itself a Christian framework. The assertion that every human being is made in the image of God, that there is neither slave nor free in Christ, that the poor are blessed and the meek will inherit the earth, was the crowbar. The abolitionists were not stepping outside of Christianity to oppose slavery. They were stepping more deeply inside of it than the slaveholders had gone. The slaveholders had the surface. The abolitionists had the core. The long arc of moral correction within the church's story is not a refutation of the story. It is the story. It is the slow working out of a seed planted at the crucifixion.

****The civil rights movement.**** The movement that dismantled American legal segregation was, at its core, a Christian movement. Martin Luther King, Jr. was not a secular humanist adapting religious language for rhetorical purposes. He was a Baptist minister whose theology was the engine of his ethics. The Southern Christian Leadership Conference was Southern and Christian and led by

ministers. The hymns the marchers sang were church hymns. The strategy was nonviolent resistance rooted in the Sermon on the Mount and the suffering servant of Isaiah. The moral authority that moved a nation came from a tradition the critic now dismisses as irredeemably racist.

Both things are true at the same time. The American church, in aggregate, was disgracefully silent or actively complicit during the civil rights era, and King wrote his famous letter from Birmingham jail in part to rebuke white pastors who had counseled patience. The same American church, through individual men and women and particular congregations, produced the movement that forced the change. The simple story the critic tells, in which Christianity is the oppressor and the liberationists were external, is not historically accurate. The liberationists were inside the tradition, reading it against the grain of its local corruption, calling the church back to itself.

That pattern, a church called back to itself by its own best voices, is the shape of the honest story. It is how slavery got ended. It is how segregation got dismantled. It is how the medieval church reformed itself more than once. It is how the early church held together through persecution. A tradition capable of self-correction is a living tradition. A tradition that only ever defends itself is dead.

The American church, in our moment, is being asked to self-correct on several fronts at once. Abuse. Political captivity. Racial reckoning. Gender and power. Biblical illiteracy. The deconstructors are, many of them, the voices calling it back to itself. Not all of them are right. Not all of their proposals are wise. But the posture, the willingness to name the failure in public and ask for better, is exactly what has, historically, kept the tradition alive. A church that listens to its own prophets, even when the prophets are angry, is a church that has a future. A church that only hunts down its prophets is a church that will not.

The next chapter is the one where we start to talk about the path

through. Not around the questions. Through them. I am going to try to say what rebuilt faith actually looks like, and what it does not look like, and why the people who have landed there will tell you it was worth the cost.

CHAPTER 7

The Path Through

There is no program for this. If there were, I would give it to you. I have watched enough people walk through the territory to know the terrain, and I can describe it. I cannot pave a road that has to be walked.

What I can do is tell you what I have watched work for the people who came out the other side with a stronger faith than they had going in, and what I have watched fail for the people who got stuck. The patterns are not formulas. They are more like the habits of good travelers. Travelers who arrive have different personalities, different pace, different routes. They share a few disciplines. Here are the disciplines.

****Read primary sources.**** The first discipline is to stop reading about the argument and start reading the argument. If the question is whether the Gospels are reliable, read the Gospels. If the question is what Paul actually said about women, read Paul's letters in their entirety, in a good translation, with a notebook next to you. If the question is what Augustine thought, read Augustine. If the question is what the Reformers actually taught about grace, read the Reformers. The secondary literature, on every side, is a field of people shouting at each other about primary sources that most of the shouters have not read carefully.

You can do this. You do not need a seminary degree. You need a Bible, a couple of introductory-level books by careful scholars on either side of the questions that matter to you, and the humility to stay with the text rather than skim it. Most deconstructors I know discover, after three months of actual reading, that both the critics and the defenders they had been listening to were working with sloppy

versions of the sources. The primary texts are almost always more interesting, more complicated, and more persuasive than the summaries you have been handed.

****Sit with the hard passages.**** The second discipline is to refuse to look away from the parts of the Bible that are difficult. The temptation, when you find a passage that unsettles you, is either to dismiss it as proof the whole book is broken or to explain it away so it stops bothering you. Both are evasions. The right move is to stay in front of the passage. Read it slowly. Read it with commentators who disagree with each other. Ask what the text would have meant to its first readers. Ask what it still means. Let the difficulty be difficult.

A passage like the binding of Isaac, or the conquest narratives, or the imprecatory psalms, or Paul on women in the Corinthian church, is not going to be resolved in an afternoon. Some of these passages have been worked on by careful readers for two thousand years and the conversation is still live. Your job is not to resolve them. Your job is to stay in the conversation. A faith that cannot live with unresolved questions is a faith that has not actually met the Bible. The Bible is not a comfort blanket. It is a text that wrestles you, like the angel wrestled Jacob, and leaves you limping. If you have not limped, you have not read.

****Find the saints who wrestled.**** The third discipline is to find out who in the history of the church asked your questions before you, and to read them. This is one of the most consoling discoveries a deconstructor can make. Whatever you are going through, somebody has gone through it before. Somebody has written about it. Somebody has come out the other side with their faith intact and has left you a map.

If you are grieving and angry at God, read the Psalms. The Psalms are a full curriculum in holy complaint. More than a third of them are laments. Psalm 88, the darkest poem in the book, ends in unresolved darkness. God put that psalm in the songbook on purpose. Your grief is in the Bible. Your anger at God is in the Bible. It is not a sign you

have left the faith. It is a sign you have finally entered it.

If you are wrestling with doubt, read Augustine's **Confessions**. Read Dostoevsky. Read the **Cloud of Unknowing**. Read Julian of Norwich, who watched a plague kill a third of her neighbors and wrote that all shall be well, and all shall be well, and all manner of thing shall be well, and did not mean it as a platitude but as a costly claim she had earned. Read Bonhoeffer writing from a Nazi prison. Read C.S. Lewis on losing his wife. Read, for that matter, Habakkuk, who stood on his watchtower and demanded God answer him and got an answer he was still working out at the end of the book.

You are not alone in this, and the people who have been here before you were not weaklings. They were saints. Some of them died for the faith after their wrestling was over. You are in their company. Let them carry you for a little while. You will return the favor, someday, for somebody you will never meet.

****Refuse the binary.**** The fourth discipline is to refuse the false choice that both the apologetics industry and the deconstruction industry want you to make. The apologetics industry wants you to believe that if you cannot resolve every doubt, your faith is broken. The deconstruction industry wants you to believe that if you cannot resolve every doubt, your faith is a lie. Both are wrong. The faith is not a deductive proof. It is a relationship with a person who rose from the dead, held in the context of a community, tested against the witness of the Scriptures and the history of the tradition. A relationship can hold unresolved questions. A living faith always has them.

What you are being asked to do is not to achieve certainty. You are being asked to commit in the direction of the truth you have seen, to keep examining, to let the unresolved questions remain unresolved for as long as they need to, and to trust that the person at the center of the faith is sturdy enough to hold your doubts without punishment. He is. Thomas did not get rebuked. He got offered wounds to touch. Your Jesus is not more fragile than Thomas's.

****Stay in a local body.**** The fifth discipline, and the hardest one for many deconstructors, is to stay embedded in an actual church during the process. Not the church you have been hurt in, necessarily. That may not be possible. But a church. A small group. A community of believers who know your name and pray for you on the weeks you cannot pray for yourself.

The deconstruction pipeline on social media is a solitary discipline that is designed to keep you isolated. The algorithm will feed you more content, more angry voices, more confirmation, more videos, more podcasts, and you will come to feel like you are in a community when in fact you are in a feed. A feed is not a community. It cannot hold your hand when your mother dies. It will not bring you a casserole when your child is in the hospital. It will not notice if you disappear. A local church, at its best, is still the place where the body of Christ shows up in bread and wine and actual bodies. You need the bodies. You cannot grow a faith in a feed.

Find a church that can bear your questions. They exist. They are not always obvious. Often they are smaller than the one that hurt you, less polished, led by pastors who are tired rather than triumphant. Sit in the back for a while. Tell one person your story. See what happens. If they can hold it, stay. If they cannot, try again somewhere else. Do not give up on the body because the body disappointed you. The body is the means of grace in the New Testament. It is how Christ keeps showing up. Without it, you are going to try to manufacture what you need, and the manufacture is going to fail.

****Practice what you are not sure of.**** The sixth discipline is the strangest one, and the one that works most reliably. Keep praying. Keep reading. Keep showing up. Even when you do not know what you believe. Especially when you do not know what you believe. The old monastic tradition called this a discipline of the body that eventually catches up with the heart. You do the practices before you feel the practices. The practices, over time, shape the self that is doing them. An atheist who started kneeling in prayer out of intellectual curiosity would, over the course of a year, not be the

same atheist. That is not manipulation. That is how bodies work.

C.S. Lewis said that prayer is not a mechanism for changing God. It is a mechanism for making ourselves into the kind of people for whom certain things are possible. The same is true of all the Christian practices. Communion, confession, singing, reading the Scriptures out loud, giving, serving, sabbath. None of them require certainty to do. All of them form a self that becomes, over time, more able to see what is actually there. You do not have to believe to practice. You have to practice to believe, and most of the time, in that order.

****Accept that the rebuild will not look identical to the original.****
The seventh discipline is a kind of permission. Your faith after the deconstruction will not look the same as your faith before. That is not a tragedy. It is the point. A renovated house is not the house it used to be. It is a better house, on the same foundation, with the load-bearing walls exposed and repaired. Some of what you used to believe was not load-bearing. You will not miss it when it is gone. Some of what you used to believe will come back reshaped, deeper, stronger, held more carefully because you know now what it cost to get there.

You may end up more theologically conservative on some issues and more politically uncommitted on others. You may end up more committed to local church and less committed to the platform-church Christian celebrity culture. You may end up more confident about the essentials and less confident about the accretions. Whatever you end up, it will be yours. Not your parents'. Not your youth pastor's. Not your favorite podcaster's. Yours, wrestled for and kept. That is what it means to have a faith. The people in Hebrews 11 had a faith like that. So can you.

It is not quick. The people who tell you they came out the other side in six months are either lying or still going. A real renovation takes years. Sometimes it takes a decade. You are not behind schedule. There is no schedule.

It is not painless. You are going to grieve. You are going to be

angry. You are going to have nights where you are not sure you believe any of it, and mornings where the grief hits you in a Kroger aisle and you have to walk out to the parking lot. This is normal. This is the shape of loss and reformation happening at the same time.

It is not without witnesses. You are not the first person to walk this. You will not be the last. There is a great cloud of them, as the writer to the Hebrews put it, who went before you and are cheering you on. The cheering is real. You cannot see them, but you can feel them in the songs you still cannot sing without crying, in the old prayers you have never been able to leave behind, in the Sunday you have decided not to go to church and somehow find yourself weeping in the kitchen. That is the cloud. They are not going away.

The path through is real. It will cost you more than you want to pay and give you more than you expected. Keep walking.

CHAPTER 8

What the Church Owes the Deconstructors

This chapter is for the pastors, the parents, the elders, the small group leaders, the church members who have been watching somebody they love walk away and do not know what to do. It is the hardest chapter in the book for me to write because the person I am indicting most severely is myself. I have done some of what I am about to name. I do not get to hand this word down from a platform. I hand it across a table.

****We owe them the truth about what we have been, and what we have covered up, and what we have gotten wrong.**** The first debt is truth-telling, and it is not the deconstructor's job to drag it out of us. We should be the ones leading. The honest accounting of the American church's failures in the last fifty years is not a concession to the critics. It is a condition of being the kind of community that could legitimately ask anyone to come back. An institution that cannot tell the truth about itself has no standing to proclaim truth to anyone else. The inability to confess is the inability to preach. The repentance has to begin at home.

This means pastors saying, from the pulpit, not on social media, not in a carefully worded statement, but on a Sunday morning, that we have defended things that should not have been defended. We have made the gospel sound like a tribal banner. We have let celebrity culture into our movement and protected celebrities at the cost of victims. We have confused the kingdom of God with a political project. We have preached purity in ways that crushed the people we should have been guarding. Specific sins named specifically, without the passive voice and without the softening adjectives. The

deconstructors are watching to see if we can do this. Almost none of them expect us to. A pastor who does it will find that some of the deconstructors in his extended family appear in the back pew on a Sunday he did not expect them. Some will not. Some will need more time. All of them will know, for the first time in years, that the truth is speakable in this building.

****We owe them honest engagement with the questions, not culture-war answers.**** A deconstructor asks about the violence in the Old Testament, and we do not get to hand them a four-sentence apologetic and go back to our sermon prep. We have to actually wrestle with the text with them. We have to be able to articulate multiple faithful Christian responses to the hard passages and let the person choose the one that fits. We have to stop performing certainty on questions the church has been internally debating for centuries. The performance is what broke their trust. Humility about what we do not know, combined with clarity about what we do, is what rebuilds it.

****We owe them a theology of suffering.**** The American church has been preaching, in many of its expressions, a functional theology of breakthrough that falls apart the first time life hits a wall. We have to replace it with the New Testament's actual theology of suffering. Paul wrote half the New Testament from prison. Peter told his readers to count it a privilege to share in Christ's sufferings. James opened his letter with instructions about trials. Jesus told his disciples in this world you will have tribulation. The entire book of Job sits in the middle of the Bible for a reason, and the answer to Job's question is not why the suffering happened but who God is in the middle of it. This is not optional material. This is the spine of the tradition. A church that has misplaced it has to recover it. The people we have been losing hit walls we told them would never come. We have to tell them the truth about walls and what God does inside them.

****We owe them the whole Bible, not only the parts that support our tribe's current position.**** This means we preach through books. We sit inside a text. We let Scripture ask us hard questions, rather

than only provide us with answers to the questions we were already asking. We stop using verses like credentials and start reading the Bible like the strange, difficult, living document it is. We let Isaiah indict our economics. We let the prophets indict our politics. We let the Sermon on the Mount indict our social media habits. We let 1 John ask whether we actually love each other. A church whose congregants have never heard a pastor preach against the church's favorite political instincts from the pulpit is a church that has not shown them what Scripture's authority looks like in practice. They have seen tribal signaling dressed up as preaching. They can tell the difference. Show them preaching. The people leaving have read the Gospels and they can tell when he is missing from the sermon.

****We owe them space to grieve out loud.**** We have to make the church a place where a woman can talk about her miscarriages and nobody tells her God has a plan. Where a young man can say he has cancer and nobody tells him God will not give him more than he can handle. Where somebody can walk in one Sunday with red eyes and the person sitting next to them can say I see you and ask no further questions. Where the prayer requests in the bulletin include things like my marriage is dying, or my child has stopped talking to me, or I am afraid I am losing my faith. Real prayer requests about real lives, not only the sanitized surgery requests we all felt safe sharing.

The church is supposed to be the place where people do not have to perform. The moment it becomes a performance space, we lose the grieving. The moment we lose the grieving, we lose the honest. The deconstructors left in part because the performance was too loud. We have to turn the performance off. We have to start being people again. This is a slow change, and it starts with the pastor. If the pastor is performing, everyone is performing. If the pastor is being a real person, people will very slowly give themselves permission to be real people too.

****We owe them a posture of welcome without compromise.**** This is the balance that the American church has had the hardest time holding. Some churches have welcomed so expansively that they no

longer stand for anything. Some churches have drawn lines so aggressively that welcome has disappeared. Jesus managed both at the same time. He invited Matthew to dinner without pretending Matthew's extortion was fine. He forgave the woman at the well without pretending she had been well. He welcomed tax collectors and prostitutes and sinners while calling them, consistently, to a different life. The posture was welcome. The ethic was costly.

The deconstructors are not, mostly, asking for the ethic to be removed. They are asking for the welcome to be real. They want to be able to come with their questions, their scars, their partial faith, and be received as human beings who are on a path, not as problems to be solved. A church that can hold that posture will see some of them come back. A church that cannot will not.

****We owe them honesty about ourselves, and our own repentance, visible and costly.**** The deconstructor is tired of pastors who are too polished. They want to see the cracks. They want to know what the pastor has doubted, what he has repented of, what he still does not have figured out. This is not a call for performative vulnerability. Performative vulnerability is the new polish. It is a call for real vulnerability, which is much harder, because it means risking your authority and discovering that, paradoxically, you gain authority by risking it.

A pastor I know stood up one Sunday and said, I do not know why my daughter is not well. I have prayed every prayer I know. Nothing has helped. I am going to preach the text now because the text is true whether my daughter is well or not, but I wanted you to know where I am. That sermon is still mentioned in that congregation ten years later. Not because of the exegesis. Because of the honesty. The deconstructors in that church heard something they had not heard from a pulpit in a long time. They heard a man who was not performing.

Here is where I have to speak personally. I have, in my earlier years of ministry, defended things I do not now defend. I have

preached with a tone of certainty about matters that deserved a tone of humility. I have fallen short with people who needed more than I gave them. If any of you who walked away from a church I led are reading this, I owe you a specific apology. I owe you a willingness to sit down and hear what went wrong, without defending myself, without explaining my intent, without trying to rescue my reputation. I owe you a repentance that costs me something.

Most pastors are going to have to do some version of this. It is not a one-time announcement. It is a posture maintained over years. A pastor who is walking in this posture will find, slowly, that the reputation of his ministry inside his own home, inside his own church, inside his own community, becomes the reputation of a man who tells the truth even when it costs him. That reputation is the only currency with which a pastor can do anything of lasting worth. We have to pay for it. It is worth what it costs.

****We owe them the long game.**** A deconstructor who walks away today may come back in three years, or seven, or seventeen. The church's job is to stay the same church they could come back to. That means we stay known. We do not go silent when they leave. We send the Christmas card. We ask after them when we see their parents. We do not push. We do not guilt. We keep the door open without making the door a trap. Some of them will come home. Some will not. The faithfulness is in the staying, not in the return rate.

I want to end this book in a minute, in an afterword that is more prayer than argument. Before I do, I want to name the hardest truth in this chapter for the people still in the room.

The American church, as a whole, has not yet done what it would take to earn the return of the people we have lost. We have not repented publicly at the scale our failures demand. We have not reformed our pulpits on the matters most in question. We have not rebuilt the trust we squandered. We are not yet a community most deconstructors could reasonably return to. That is not an indictment of every local congregation. There are churches doing this work,

quietly, faithfully, in places nobody is watching. They are the seeds of the church that will be. Most of us have more work to do.

If you are a pastor reading this and you recognize yourself and your church in what I have named, the response is not despair. The response is to begin. Begin tomorrow. Begin the sermon you have been afraid to preach. Begin the repentance you have been avoiding. Begin the conversation with the person whose number is still in your phone and whose face you still see in the third pew on Sundays that have not happened in a long time. Begin. The church has always reformed itself one faithful beginning at a time. Ours will too. Or we will not reform, and we will disappear, and a different church will be raised up in our place, and that will also be the mercy of God.

A word, finally, to the deconstructor who has made it to the end of this book.

I do not know what you are going to decide. I am not trying to manipulate you into a decision. I am trying to tell you the truth I have found, so that whatever you decide, you decide with the truth available to you. The church you left may not be a church worth returning to. Jesus is still worth returning to. The church at her best, and she is not always at her best, is the body that carries him forward in the world. Find her. Or let her find you. She is not always who she has seemed to be. Underneath the accretions, she is the people of God, and you are welcome among them, and we have been praying for you in ways you do not know. Come when you are ready. Stay away if you need to. Either way, we love you, and the Shepherd has not taken his eyes off you.

CHAPTER 9

The Sociology of Loss: Why This Generation, Why Now

Every generation has its doubters. Every era has produced people who walked away from the faith they were handed. What we are watching now is different in scale and character, and it is worth asking why. The question is not whether people have always left. They have. The question is why this particular generation, raised in this particular version of American Christianity, is leaving at rates that have no precedent in the modern history of the American church. Answering that honestly requires setting down the preferred explanation most pastors reach for, which is that the culture has gotten worse and faithfulness has gotten harder, and picking up a harder set of tools.

The preferred explanation is not entirely wrong. The culture has shifted. Secularism has advanced. The plausibility structures that used to make belief in God seem obvious have weakened. Charles Taylor has given us language for this, and his language is useful. We live in what he calls the immanent frame, a cultural condition in which the natural order feels like the only order, and the transcendent has to be argued for rather than assumed. That shift is real and it makes faith harder to hold in the way the people of a thousand years ago held it without effort. A young person today does not inherit belief the way their great-grandparents did. Belief has become a choice, and choice has become a burden.

But the culture-is-worse explanation is incomplete and often self-serving. It lets the church off the hook. It treats the loss as external weather rather than internal rot. The generational data does not actually support the claim that American secularism alone accounts

for the scale of the departure. Secularism has been advancing in Europe for a century, and the American church looked at European decline for decades and congratulated itself on being different. Something else happened here, in the last forty years, that broke the trust. You cannot understand it by looking only at the culture. You have to look at the church.

The deconstruction wave is a delayed reckoning with specific choices the American church made in the last generation, and the generational character of the exodus tells you that those choices have an expiration date. The children and grandchildren of the people who made those choices are now adults, and they are filing their assessments.

Consider what shaped this generation. They are the first Americans who grew up entirely inside a culture war that the church was understood to be a combatant in. Their parents came of age in a church that was still, in some ways, a cultural default. My parents' generation could attend a church in which politics was present but not primary. By the time my own children were in youth group, the political valence of American evangelicalism was no longer implicit. It was the thing. You could not attend a large American evangelical church in the 2010s without encountering political signaling as a core feature of the experience. The worship service wrapped itself in a flag. The sermons named the cultural enemies. The bookstore carried the campaign-season paperbacks. The faith the young people received was not a faith they could separate from the politics. By the time they were old enough to think about it, they could not imagine evangelical Christianity as anything but a political tribe that happened to have a god.

That was a choice the church made. It did not have to make that choice. There were voices at the time warning against it. Those voices were marginalized. The choice was made anyway, because the political alignment felt like power, and power felt like the way to protect the things the church valued. A generation watched the church choose power, and the generation is now telling us what they

saw. They saw a church that traded its soul for a seat at a table. They saw a church that defended men who should not have been defended, endorsed candidates whose character violated everything the church claimed to care about, and justified it all with appeals to lesser-evil calculation that, when pressed, turned into appeals to tribal loyalty. The young person in the pew who watched this happen did not have the theological vocabulary to articulate what was wrong, but they could feel it. The feeling was that the people in charge did not mean what they said. The feeling was that the beliefs were costume jewelry.

A generation that feels that its elders did not mean what they said does not leave the faith first. It leaves the institution. It says, in effect, I will keep Jesus but I will not keep this church, because this church has shown me that its public commitments are negotiable and its private commitments are power. The institution reads the exit as apostasy. The young person reads it as integrity. The tragedy is that the young person is often more right than wrong, and the institution does not have the self-knowledge to hear it.

This is why so many deconstruction stories have a specific shape. They do not start with a doctrinal objection. They start with a moral revulsion. Something happened, in the young person's home church or in the national news, that exposed the gap between what the church said and what the church did. The young person brought the gap up, usually first to a parent, and was shut down. They brought it up to a pastor, and were told they were being influenced by the world. They brought it up in Bible study, and watched other adults rally to the defense of whatever had exposed the gap. The young person learned that the church did not want the conversation. They learned that the adults in the room had decided in advance what the answer had to be, and anyone who pushed against that answer would be reframed as the problem. The deconstruction, at that point, is already underway. The young person has not yet left the building. They have already left the trust.

There is a second factor worth naming, and it is more diffuse but equally important. This is the first generation that grew up with the

internet. They did not just hear the church's version of the church's story. They also heard every other version, from every other source, with a speed and density no previous generation had to process. When a denomination mishandled an abuse case, the young person in the youth group did not have to wait for the national media to cover it. They saw it on a podcast a week after it broke. When a celebrity pastor fell, they watched the fall in real time, and then they watched the statements from the surrounding institutions, and then they watched the statements get revised as new facts emerged, and then they watched the gap between the original statements and the final facts. They developed, as a cohort, a forensic sense for institutional evasion. They can smell a non-apology apology at a distance. They can tell when a press release is written by a lawyer. They grew up being trained by the medium to notice institutional dishonesty, and when they turn that trained attention on the church, they find plenty.

This is not a cultural failure on their part. It is a feature of the world they live in. Any church strategy that assumes the young person can be persuaded to trust the institution on the institution's own say-so is operating on a model of trust that expired before the young person was born. Trust in the medium of the internet is earned by transparency, by acknowledgment of mistakes, by willingness to be contradicted, and by consistency over time. None of those are strengths of the American evangelical institution. The institution was built for a different media ecosystem and has not adapted. Its habits of speech and its rhythms of crisis management belong to an era when it could control the conversation. The era of controlled conversation is over. The institution has not caught up.

A third factor: this generation has a different relationship to suffering than the generations that preceded it, and the relationship is worth taking seriously before you dismiss it. They have been told, from kindergarten forward, that their feelings matter, that pain is real, that trauma is a legitimate category of experience, and that healing is a legitimate goal. Some of this is a cultural excess. Some of it is therapeutic language escaping the clinical setting where it belongs.

But some of it is a genuine correction against the emotional repression that shaped earlier generations. The correction has limits. It can slide into a self-absorbed fragility that treats every discomfort as trauma. But the correction is not nothing. And the church that wants to minister to this generation has to meet it inside its emotional vocabulary, not outside it.

The problem is that much of American evangelical preaching operates with an implicit anthropology that treats emotional pain as a sign of insufficient faith. The young person comes forward with real grief, real anxiety, real depression, and is given a verse. The verse is not wrong. The verse is simply insufficient. The young person needed a verse and a human being. They got half. When they go outside the church and find a therapist, and the therapist takes their pain seriously for the first time in their life, the therapist wins their trust in a way the church never did. The church then reads the therapist's influence as secular drift. The young person reads it as someone finally listening. You can see who is likely to retain the relationship.

A fourth factor: this generation has watched, more closely than any generation before it, the cost of institutional silence on specific moral questions. They watched the Catholic abuse crisis. They watched the Southern Baptist abuse crisis. They watched the coverups in large nondenominational networks. They watched how long the institutions took to admit what everyone already knew. They watched how the institutions treated survivors during the admission process. They have absorbed, at the level of cellular memory, a truth that their parents were able to more easily ignore. The truth is that institutional self-protection is the default instinct of every institution, including the church, and that the church's claim to moral authority is only as strong as its willingness to act against its own self-interest when the moral stakes require it. They have watched the church mostly fail that test. They are not willing to pretend otherwise.

You can, if you are the kind of pastor who likes this sort of answer, complain about this generation's insistence on consistency. You can say they are self-righteous. You can say they are ungracious.

You can say they do not understand that institutions are made of people and that people are flawed. All of these things are partially true. But the deeper truth is that this generation learned its standards of institutional behavior from the same institutions it is now criticizing. The church taught them that character matters. The church taught them that hypocrisy is a sin. The church taught them that leaders should be above reproach. They absorbed the teaching. They applied it to the teachers. The teachers failed the test. The students are now behaving exactly as the teachers told them to behave. The teachers do not like being held to the standards they themselves set.

A fifth factor, and this one is more subtle. This generation has a different relationship to authority than any generation before it, and that relationship has been shaped not primarily by the academy or by progressive politics, as the cultural-decline narrative claims, but by the internet and by the experience of watching every traditional authority expose itself in real time. They watched the media lie about Iraq. They watched the financial institutions lie about the housing bubble. They watched the medical institutions fumble the pandemic. They watched the political institutions abandon norms that the institutions themselves had spent decades telling them were sacred. By the time they were old enough to be asked to trust the church, they had already been trained to assume that every institution lies as a matter of course, and that claims of moral authority are mostly cover for the institution's real agenda.

You can argue with that framework. You can say it is too cynical, and it probably is. But you cannot pretend it does not exist. The church that ministers to this generation has to understand that trust in authority itself is at historic lows, that the church does not get a pass on that larger distrust, and that the church will have to earn trust the way every other institution has to earn it in this era. The era when the church could expect deference because it was the church is over. The era when a pastor's word carried automatic weight because of the role is over. The role is not gone. The deference is.

What does this mean for the pastor who wants to take the generational character of this exit seriously? A few things.

First, take the institutional critique seriously on its own terms rather than reframing it as a spiritual problem. The young person in your congregation who says that evangelicalism has been corrupted by politics is making a claim that can be engaged. You can engage it by showing them where your church has not been corrupted, where your preaching has pushed back against the political captivity, where your moral witness has been consistent rather than tribal. If you cannot show those things, then they have a point, and you have work to do. The first step is not to defend the institution. The first step is to be an institution worth defending.

Second, acknowledge the internet reality. You are not competing with the Gospel of Thomas anymore. You are competing with a forty-minute well-sourced podcast on your denomination's recent abuse coverup. The young person is going to consume that podcast. You cannot prevent it. What you can do is be the kind of leader whose response to it is credible. You can be the pastor who, when the denomination's report drops, names the failure from the pulpit before the young person asks about it. You can be the pastor who, when a local case of pastoral misconduct surfaces, does not rush to defend the accused but commits to due process with a bias toward the vulnerable. You can be the pastor whose response to institutional failure is institutional repentance, not institutional damage control. The young person is watching. They will notice.

Third, develop a pastoral theology of emotional experience that does not treat feelings as a category to be corrected with doctrine. Feelings are data. They are not the final word, but they are data. A person in real grief needs Scripture, but they also need to be allowed to grieve. A person with real anxiety needs the Psalms, but they also need to be told that the anxiety is not a sin. A person who has been through real trauma needs the cross, but they also need to be told that what happened to them was not God's will, that God grieves with them, that the path through is longer than a verse. The church that

cannot say those things will lose the young person in the first serious crisis of their adult life. The church that can say them will have the chance to keep them.

Fourth, understand that the moral consistency demand is not going away, and do not resent it. The generation that grew up watching institutions fail its own stated values is not going to extend credit to any institution, including yours, on the strength of claim alone. Credit has to be earned, repeatedly, by action. If you want the young person to stay, you have to be the kind of pastor and the kind of church whose practice matches the preaching, and whose response to the inevitable mismatch is honest confession rather than spin. This is not a lowering of the bar. It is a return to the bar the church itself set and then mostly abandoned.

Fifth, remember that the generation you are trying to keep is not uniform. Some of them will leave no matter what you do. Some will come back later. Some are in the middle, watchful, looking for signs. The ones in the middle are the ones a faithful pastor can still reach, not by performance but by the slow, unglamorous work of being a pastor whose integrity the young person can check against reality. Be that person while you can.

The sociology of the loss is not destiny. The generational factors are not deterministic. Individual pastors and individual congregations can still make a difference. But the difference will be made only by leaders who understand what the young person is actually experiencing, which is not a failure of cultural faithfulness in an increasingly hostile environment. It is a reckoning with specific choices the American church made, over the last forty years, that the young person has now had time to assess. The reckoning is not going to be stopped by louder preaching or harder catechism. It is going to be stopped, where it is stopped at all, by churches that repent of what was wrong, keep what was right, and build something the young person can tell the truth inside of. That is the work. It is slower than a program. It is harder than a conference. It is the only thing that will hold.

CHAPTER 10

Science, Creation, and the False Choice

The deconstructor I am thinking about as I write this chapter was raised in a household where evolution was presented as a lie and the age of the universe was presented as roughly six thousand years and the geological record was presented as evidence of Noah's flood. He is now thirty. He took two semesters of biology in college, read a few books on cosmology for fun, and eventually came to the conclusion that the scientific account of the natural world is, on its own terms, compelling. He did not set out to reject his childhood faith. He set out to understand the world. The rejection followed because he had been told, by the adults in his life and by the books they gave him to read, that to accept the scientific account was to reject the Bible. He accepted the scientific account. He assumed the rejection was required. Nobody had given him the resources to think otherwise.

This story is not rare. It is one of the most common shapes of deconstruction, and it is entirely preventable. The preventability is what makes it infuriating. Generations of Christian thinkers, going back to Augustine in the fourth century, have refused to set up the choice between Scripture and the natural order as a choice. Augustine said that if what we think the Bible teaches conflicts with what we can demonstrate about the natural world, we should reexamine our reading of the Bible, because the God who wrote the one also authored the other. That was not liberalism. That was not accommodation. That was the mainstream Christian tradition operating with confidence that its God was the God of all truth. The American evangelical tradition, in the last hundred years, decided to set aside that confidence and set up instead a cage match between a

particular reading of Genesis and a particular caricature of modern science. The young person walked into the cage match, saw that the cage was rigged, and walked back out. They took the faith with them when they left, assuming that was the only option. It was not.

This chapter is going to say some things that will be uncomfortable for pastors and congregations that have built identity around a young-earth, anti-evolutionary posture. I am not asking anyone to abandon convictions. I am asking that the posture be held with a kind of honesty that has often been missing. If you are a young-earth creationist, hold that position because you have examined the arguments on both sides and concluded that the young-earth position has the better of the argument. Do not hold it because you have been told that to hold otherwise is to deny the faith. That claim is historically false, theologically shallow, and pastorally catastrophic. It is responsible, directly, for the loss of a significant percentage of the young people who have left the evangelical church over the last thirty years. The blood is on the hands of the leaders who taught them that the Bible required a posture it does not, in fact, require.

Let me work the argument carefully, because this is ground on which a lot of trust gets lost.

The opening chapters of Genesis are extraordinary pieces of ancient literature. They function as theological polemic against the surrounding ancient Near Eastern creation myths, and they make their arguments by adopting some of the structural features of those myths while subverting their content. The other creation accounts of the ancient Near East featured multiple gods in conflict, humans made from the blood of defeated deities as slaves, and a cosmos that was precarious and arbitrary. Genesis 1 and 2 feature one God who speaks the world into being, humans made in the divine image with royal dignity, and a cosmos that is ordered and good. This is the theological heavy lifting the text is doing. It is telling the Israelites what kind of world they live in, what kind of God made it, and what kind of creatures they are inside it. This is what the text is for.

What the text is not for is what a modern scientific textbook is for. It is not providing a chronology of the geological record. It is not specifying the mechanisms by which species arose. It is not giving an astronomical account of stellar formation. The questions a scientist asks are not the questions the text was written to answer. To force the text to answer them, and then to evaluate the answer against the findings of modern scientific work, is to misuse the text in a way that its own authors would not recognize. The early church fathers knew this. They read Genesis 1 allegorically, figuratively, and symbolically as often as they read it literally, and they saw no conflict in doing so because they understood the text was a different genre than natural history.

The young-earth position, in anything like its contemporary form, is a product of the early twentieth century. It was not the majority position of the Christian tradition before 1920. It became prominent in the American fundamentalist movement through the work of George McCready Price, a Seventh-day Adventist, and it was popularized for the broader evangelical world by Henry Morris and John Whitcomb in 1961 with the publication of *The Genesis Flood*. That book, more than any other, shaped the creationist movement of the late twentieth century, and it presented its conclusions as if they were the historic Christian position. They were not. They were a recent interpretive move, built on questionable geology, and pitched to a population that did not have the tools to evaluate the geological claims on their merits.

None of this means the young-earth position is without defenders today, or that every argument for it is bad. Some of its defenders are careful and honest. But the framing that has been handed down to most American evangelical young people is not careful or honest. The framing is that to accept an old earth is to compromise biblical authority, that to accept common descent is to deny the gospel, and that any Christian who accepts the mainstream scientific account has been captured by the world. This framing is false at every level. The history of Christian interpretation does not support it. The theology

of Scripture does not require it. And the pastoral fruit of it is, as we are watching in real time, catastrophic.

Let me put it more directly. If the cost of holding the young-earth line has been that a significant portion of the rising generation has concluded that Christianity itself is intellectually indefensible, then the line has been too expensive. Jesus did not die for six-day creation. The gospel is not contingent on the age of the earth. The church has survived every previous scientific revolution, including the Copernican one that was far more threatening to its worldview than anything on offer today, and the church has survived because, every time, there were Christian thinkers who did the hard work of showing that the faith could hold the new knowledge without losing its core. The church that refuses to do that work in the present is not defending the gospel. It is abandoning the young people that the gospel exists to save.

Now, a word about evolution, because the word is doing so much work in so many Christian conversations that it has almost lost its meaning. Evolution, as the term is used in mainstream biology, refers to the change in heritable traits in a population over generations, through mechanisms that include natural selection, genetic drift, and mutation. It is one of the best-supported theories in the history of science, supported by converging evidence from paleontology, comparative anatomy, molecular biology, and direct observation of populations over time. The evidence is not controversial among working biologists. What is sometimes controversial is the philosophical extrapolation from the theory, the claim that evolution demonstrates the nonexistence of God, or the claim that it reduces human beings to material machines with no spiritual reality. These are philosophical claims, not scientific ones, and Christians can rightly push back on them. But the scientific core, the claim that life developed over deep time through natural processes, is not in scientific dispute, and it is not theologically in conflict with anything the Bible actually teaches.

A Christian can hold that God is the creator, that human beings

bear the divine image, that the soul is a real and non-reducible reality, that sin is real and catastrophic and in need of redemption, and that Jesus is the incarnate Son of God who died and rose again, while also accepting that the natural order is roughly 13.8 billion years old, that the earth is 4.5 billion years old, that life developed through evolutionary processes, and that humans share common ancestors with other primates. Christians have held that synthesis for over a century. Many of the most influential theologians of the twentieth century, including C. S. Lewis, held some form of it. The synthesis does not require abandoning any core Christian conviction. It requires only abandoning the assumption that Genesis 1 and 2 were intended to function as a scientific account. That assumption is not biblical. It is cultural.

If the pastor reading this chapter is not ready to adopt the synthesis, I am not asking you to. I am asking you to do one thing. Stop telling the young people in your congregation that accepting mainstream science is the same as rejecting the Bible. Stop it because it is false and stop it because the cost is unconscionable. You can hold your interpretive position without requiring your entire congregation to hold it. You can teach the interpretive options honestly and let the congregation work through them with you. The church father Augustine, in his commentary on Genesis, explicitly warned against Christians making definitive interpretive claims about Scripture in areas where natural philosophy was still being worked out, because he saw that such overconfidence would turn outsiders away from the faith over nothing. He was right in the fourth century. He is right now. The young people we have been losing have been losing their faith, in many cases, over exactly the thing Augustine warned against. The warning has been available for sixteen hundred years. The church that did not listen is now counting the costs.

Let me turn, briefly, to the positive case. A Christianity that can receive the findings of modern science is not a diminished Christianity. It is, in some ways, a richer one. The universe is older, larger, and stranger than the young-earth framework allowed. The

creation story, read against the backdrop of cosmology, is not less awe-inspiring but more so. Billions of years of stars forming and dying to produce the heavy elements that make up your body. Galaxies colliding across timescales that dwarf the entire human story. Life developing on this one small planet through mechanisms whose elegance is its own kind of argument for design. The doctrine of creation, as it turns out, is not small enough to fit into six literal days, and it never was. The text was pointing toward something grander than the readings imposed on it. The grand thing is still there, if we will let the text be what it is and let the creation speak in its own voice.

The young person who has been told, all their life, that to follow the evidence is to leave the faith, hears that frame as an ultimatum. Many of them choose the evidence, because the evidence is compelling. The gift a faithful pastor can give them is the removal of the ultimatum. You can tell them, with a straight face and a good conscience, that the evidence is not the enemy. That the God of the Bible is also the God of the physical universe. That the scientific method, used honestly, is a gift, and that its findings do not threaten the faith but enrich it. That the doctrine of creation is larger than any interpretation we will put on Genesis 1, and that the person of Jesus Christ is not even remotely contingent on the resolution of evolutionary questions.

This is not a compromise. It is the historic Christian confidence. It is the faith of Augustine, of Aquinas, and of C. S. Lewis. It is not a modern liberal accommodation. It is what the tradition has looked like, most of the time, when it was operating at its best. The American evangelical movement of the last century decided, unfortunately, to narrow the tradition to an interpretive position that the tradition did not uniformly hold, and then to present that narrow position as the only faithful one. That was a mistake. The mistake has been costly. It is not too late to stop making it.

Practically, what does this look like in a local church?

First, preach through Genesis 1 and 2 as the ancient theological literature they are, and let the text do what the text was written to do. Show the congregation the polemical work the text is doing against the surrounding cultures. Show them the poetic structure. Show them the Hebrew wordplay. Show them the way the text reserves the image of God for every human being, which was a radical claim in its original context. Do this before you ever talk about days and dinosaurs. Let the congregation see that the text is not small.

Second, when you do address the scientific questions, address them with honesty about what the text does and does not claim, and with humility about the interpretive options the tradition has held. Present young-earth creationism as one of the options, with its defenders and its difficulties. Present old-earth creationism. Present evolutionary creationism. Do not pretend one of them is the only faithful position. Let the congregation see that thoughtful Christians have held various views, and that the faith does not depend on the resolution.

Third, build, in your congregation, a posture of curiosity about the natural world that reflects the goodness of creation. Take your people outside. Read them David Attenborough. Show them the telescopes. Let them see that the world God made is an endless source of wonder, and that Christians have no reason to be afraid of any of it. A congregation that loves the world God made will be harder to shake when the world turns up something unexpected.

Fourth, when young people come to you with questions that grow out of their science classes, do not shut them down. Do not tell them their college biology professor is a Marxist ideologue. Do not hand them a DVD from 1998 that purports to debunk carbon dating. Listen to the question. Take it seriously. Say, I do not know everything about this. Let me look into it. Get back to me. That sentence, from a pastor, is worth more than a thousand confident wrong answers.

Fifth, find the books and the resources. The BioLogos organization, founded by Francis Collins, has done good work

helping Christians engage the scientific questions without losing the faith. Alister McGrath has written carefully and well. John Polkinghorne, before his death, produced a body of work that any pastor can point a questioning young person toward. There are resources. Use them. Stop handing young people the books from the 1980s that pretended dinosaurs and humans lived together. Those books were wrong when they were written, and they are embarrassing now, and the young person who reads them after taking a college science course will never trust your recommendations again.

The old battle, the one between a flat-footed biblical literalism and mainstream science, is a battle the church was always going to lose, because the battle was fought on terms the church did not need to accept. The choice was never between the Bible and science. The choice was between a recent American evangelical reading of Genesis and the findings of the natural sciences. The reading can be corrected. The sciences will not be rolled back. A faith that has defined itself by the reading is a faith that is hemorrhaging the generation that has followed the sciences. A faith that defines itself by the person of Jesus Christ is a faith that can hold the sciences, ask larger questions than the sciences ask, and offer answers the sciences cannot give. That faith is still available. The young person who left over the false choice is still reachable, if you can give them the faith you should have given them in the first place.

I do not write this chapter as an outsider to this debate. I grew up in the evangelical world that presented the false choice. I believed it for longer than I should have. I had to do my own reading, my own thinking, my own repentance, to come out the other side of it. When I look at my own five sons, I know that I will not repeat with them the mistake my teachers made with me. I will not require them to choose between the faith that saved me and the natural order their God made. I will show them that the faith is large enough to hold both. I will tell them the truth about the history of the interpretive options. I will let them think for themselves, and trust that the God who made them, mind and all, will meet them in the thinking. That is the least the

church can do for the next generation. It is more than most of the church has been willing to do for the last one. The difference can start in your congregation, this Sunday, with a single honest sentence from the pulpit.

CHAPTER 11

The Problem of Hell Revisited

The question of hell is, for many deconstructors, the doctrine that pushed them over the edge. They could live with a lot of things. They could live with the tension between providence and suffering. They could live with the strange bits of the Old Testament. They could live with the church's political captivity by holding their nose and finding a different congregation. What they could not live with was a doctrine of eternal conscious torment presented as if it were the natural reading of Scripture and as if any Christian who held a different view had denied the faith. The doctrine, as they received it, made God into a moral monster. The monster did not match the Jesus of the Gospels. The mismatch became unsupportable. Faith broke.

This chapter is going to try to do something careful. It is going to argue that the church, in the way it has often talked about hell, has been louder than the Bible, more confident than the tradition, and less pastoral than the doctrine itself requires. It is also going to argue that the popular evangelical position on hell is only one of several positions that faithful Christians have held across the history of the church, and that presenting it as the only faithful position is a form of parochialism that has cost the church dearly. I am not writing this chapter to settle the question. I am writing to say that the question has not been settled by most of the voices that have settled it loudest, and that the young person who left because they could not accept the loud position deserves to know that there were always quieter options within the faith.

Start with the vocabulary. The English word hell is used in most translations to render several different words from the biblical languages, and those words do not all mean the same thing. The Hebrew word Sheol referred, in most Old Testament usage, to the

grave or the underworld, a shadowy place where the dead, righteous and wicked, were understood to go. It was not primarily a place of torment. The Greek word Hades, used in the Septuagint to translate Sheol and then again in the New Testament, carries a similar range of meaning. The Greek word Gehenna, used by Jesus in the Gospels, refers literally to the Valley of Hinnom outside Jerusalem, a place associated in the prophets with terrible judgment because of the historic idolatry that had happened there. The Greek word Tartarus, used once in 2 Peter, refers to a pit for fallen angels. These are four different words with four different ranges of meaning, and collapsing all of them into one English word with one doctrinal content is already a translation decision that shapes what the reader thinks the Bible is saying.

A young person who encounters these linguistic facts for the first time, often in a college religion course or on a podcast, is going to be disoriented. They were told the Bible had a clear doctrine of hell. Now they are learning that the English word hell is doing an enormous amount of interpretive work that the underlying languages do not do in the same way. The disorientation can tip into cynicism. They begin to wonder what else has been presented as plain biblical teaching when it was actually interpretive tradition. The cynicism is not entirely unwarranted. The plain-reading claim, applied to complex biblical texts, has done more damage to young faith than almost any other rhetorical habit of the evangelical pulpit.

Take the teaching of Jesus specifically. Jesus spoke about judgment a great deal, and the language he used was vivid and serious. Weeping and gnashing of teeth. Fire that is not quenched. The worm that does not die. These are terrifying images, and any honest reading of the Gospels has to reckon with the fact that Jesus used them. What is less clear, from the texts themselves, is exactly what Jesus meant by them. The images are drawn from the Old Testament, particularly from Isaiah 66, where the unquenchable fire and the undying worm refer to the corpses of those judged outside Jerusalem, not to living beings in conscious torment. The fire burns

and the worm consumes, because there is nothing left to burn or consume, not because the burning is an ongoing punishment of an ongoing victim. This is not a fringe reading. It is what the text Jesus was quoting actually says.

Does that settle the question of what Jesus meant? No. But it means that the confident claim, made from many evangelical pulpits, that Jesus clearly taught a doctrine of eternal conscious torment is overstated. Jesus used images whose original Old Testament referent was the destruction of the wicked, and he applied them to the final judgment. Whether he intended those images to carry forward the Old Testament referent, which is destruction, or whether he intended to transform them into something new, which is endless torment, is a matter on which careful Christians have disagreed.

Three positions have a long history in the church and have been held by Christians who were, by any reasonable measure, orthodox and serious. The first is eternal conscious torment, the position most American evangelicals have received as the default. It holds that the wicked, at the final judgment, are consigned to a state of conscious suffering that never ends. This position has support from certain readings of Matthew 25 and Revelation 20, and it was held by some of the early fathers. The second is conditional immortality, sometimes called annihilationism. It holds that the wicked, at the final judgment, are destroyed, so that their existence ends. This position was held by some early fathers, has been defended in the modern period by careful evangelical scholars like John Stott and Edward Fudge, and has significant biblical support from the language of destruction, perishing, and the second death that runs through the New Testament. The third is universal reconciliation, sometimes called Christian universalism. It holds that all, in the end, will be reconciled to God through Christ, though possibly after a period of judgment and purification. This position was held by some of the greatest minds of the early church, including Gregory of Nyssa, who was never declared a heretic for it, and has had serious defenders through the centuries, including, in the modern period, theologians like David

Bentley Hart.

I am not, in this chapter, going to argue for one of these over the others. I am going to argue that the evangelical church has often presented the first position as if the other two did not exist or were self-evidently heretical. That presentation is historically false and pastorally ruinous. Many of the people who have walked away from Christianity over the doctrine of hell walked away from a version of the doctrine that the tradition as a whole did not unanimously hold, and they walked away because nobody ever told them that there were other options.

Why did nobody tell them? Partly because the leaders they listened to did not know. A lot of American evangelical pastoral training, especially outside the seminaries that do the careful work, does not expose pastors to the full range of the tradition on this question. The pastor who has only encountered the eternal conscious torment position will assume it is the only option and will preach it that way. Partly because the doctrine of hell has been used, in too many evangelical settings, as an evangelistic lever, and weakening the lever feels like weakening the evangelism. Partly because there is a cultural fear, understandable but not defensible, that opening the question will collapse into universalism, and universalism is understood to remove all urgency from the Christian life. None of these reasons rise to the level of a good reason to keep silent about the actual range of Christian thought on this question.

Here is what I want to say to the young person who has walked away because they could not accept the version of the doctrine they were handed. You walked away from a version. The version was not nothing. It had defenders. But it was not the only option, and the fact that it was presented to you as the only option was a failure of teaching, not a test of your faithfulness. If you can hold the door open a little longer, there are other things worth considering.

Consider that even in the most traditional reading, hell is not something God does to people. It is, on most careful accounts, the

state of the soul that has decisively and finally refused God. C. S. Lewis put it as memorably as anyone. The door of hell is locked on the inside. The wicked, on this view, are not screaming to get out while God keeps them in. They are in the state they have chosen, which is separation from the love they have rejected, and the suffering is the shape of that rejection made permanent. This is not the cartoon version of hell. The cartoon version, with a red devil and a pitchfork and a gleeful God of vengeance, has more to do with Dante and with medieval Italian art than with anything the Bible teaches or the serious tradition has held.

Consider that the New Testament writers, when they talk about final judgment, lean heavily on language of perishing, destruction, and death. The wages of sin is death, not eternal life in torment. The broad road leads to destruction. The chaff is burned up. The branch is cut off and burned. These images can be read in a way that supports eternal conscious torment, but they can also, with equal textual legitimacy, be read as supporting a view in which the unredeemed cease to be. The second position, conditional immortality, has gained serious support among evangelical scholars in the last fifty years for exactly this reason. It fits the language of the New Testament better than its critics admit, and it resolves the moral problem the young person is raising in a way that the first position cannot.

Consider that the early church did not operate with one unified doctrine of hell and did not treat disagreement on this question as the line between orthodoxy and heresy. Gregory of Nyssa, whose trinitarian theology is foundational for orthodox Christianity, was a Christian universalist. Origen, more controversially, held a version of the same view. The council that eventually censured some universalist positions, the Fifth Ecumenical Council in 553, was ratifying a position that had become dominant by then, but it did not eliminate the disagreement entirely, and it did not retroactively declare Gregory of Nyssa a heretic. The orthodox tradition has, in fact, had more room on this question than most contemporary evangelicals realize. That room is available to you.

Consider that the motivation behind the doctrine as it has been taught in evangelical settings is, frequently, a desire to protect the seriousness of the gospel. That motivation is not wrong. The gospel is serious, the stakes are real, and any account of judgment that collapses the seriousness has given something up. But a doctrine can protect seriousness in more than one way. A doctrine that says the unrepentant perish and cease to be is serious. A doctrine that says the unrepentant are finally reconciled after a refining judgment is serious. The seriousness does not require the specific picture of eternal torment to do its work. The gospel's urgency can survive a reconsideration of the doctrine's exact shape.

What should a pastor do with all of this, given that most congregations are not ready for a fifteen-week seminary lecture on the history of eschatological thought?

First, stop preaching confident claims that exceed the actual evidence. If you have held, for most of your ministry, a version of eternal conscious torment, you can continue to hold it while acknowledging that other serious Christians have held other positions. That acknowledgment, from the pulpit, costs you almost nothing and buys the young person a reason to stay. The alternative is a kind of overclaiming that, when the young person finds out the truth about the history of Christian thought on this question, will look like dishonesty and will cost you every ounce of credibility you had.

Second, when you do preach on judgment, focus on the person of the Judge rather than on the mechanics of the sentence. The Judge is Jesus. The Jesus we meet in the Gospels is the one who will judge. If that reframing creates problems for you, good. Sit with the problems. Let them do their work. The cartoon Jesus who loves you unconditionally in this life and then presides over eternal torture in the next is not the Jesus of the Gospels. He is a Frankenstein stitched together from half-read texts. The real Jesus is more complicated and more trustworthy than that.

Third, take the moral objection seriously rather than dismissing it

as a sign that the objector does not understand holiness. The young person who says, I cannot worship a God who would eternally torture people for a finite life of finite sin, is making an argument that every serious Christian has had to wrestle with. You can disagree with the conclusion. You cannot dismiss the argument. Every defender of the traditional doctrine, from Augustine forward, has had to grapple with the proportionality problem. The grappling has produced a range of answers, some of which are serious and some of which are evasive. The young person is not wrong to notice.

Fourth, recover the tradition. Read Gregory of Nyssa. Read Origen. Read Edward Fudge. Read John Stott's two-volume work and see an evangelical statesman defend conditional immortality in careful biblical terms. Read David Bentley Hart's *That All Shall Be Saved*, not because you will agree with it, but because you need to see what a serious defense of universalism actually looks like rather than the caricature you have been handed. Read the Catholic tradition on purgatory, which is not the same as hell but illuminates how the tradition has thought about the posthumous condition. Let the tradition talk back to you. You will come out of that reading with more respect for the positions you still do not hold and with more humility about the positions you do.

Fifth, preach the love of God with the same confidence you have preached the wrath of God. The New Testament does not give you the right to separate these. The cross of Christ is simultaneously the revelation of the wrath and of the love, and any preaching that has emphasized one without the other has given the congregation a half-gospel. If your sermons over the last ten years have been heavy on judgment and light on love, correct the balance. Not because love is the only thing. Because love is the larger thing. The wrath exists inside the love, not alongside it. A God who does not love is not the Christian God. A God who only threatens is not the Christian God either.

To the young person who left over hell, I want to say this directly. Your moral objection was not a sign of spiritual weakness. It was a

sign of moral seriousness. The doctrine as you received it deserved the objection. What was missing was the rest of the conversation. The rest of the conversation is available. You do not have to accept the cartoon. You do not have to accept the version that was handed to you in youth group by a leader who himself had never thought carefully about it. You can read the tradition. You can look at the biblical texts with fresh eyes. You can come back to a faith that is, as it turns out, bigger and stranger and more humane than the one you rejected.

The God of the Bible is not a torturer. The God of the Bible is the Father who runs to meet the prodigal while he is still a long way off. The Judge of the final judgment is the same Judge who wept over Jerusalem and said, How often I would have gathered your children together. Whatever final judgment means, it means something that is consistent with that Judge, because that Judge is who he is. The doctrine of hell, held honestly, has to be held inside that portrait. When it has been held outside that portrait, it has become something other than the Christian doctrine, and the young person who rejected it was often, without knowing it, rejecting something the Christian tradition itself has partly rejected.

Come back and ask again. Ask with the range of the tradition open in front of you. Ask with teachers who are not afraid of the questions. Ask the Jesus of the Gospels what he meant by the things he said, and be willing for the answers to surprise you. The door is not locked from the outside. It was never locked from the outside. The Father is watching the road.

CHAPTER 12

Sexuality, the Body, and the Scriptural Imagination

I have said already in this book that the Bible is more sexually conservative than most of the cultural options on offer today. That remains my position and I do not expect to retreat from it. What I want to do in this chapter is press harder on a question that is more difficult than the sexual ethics debate is usually allowed to be, which is why so many people leave the faith over the church's handling of sexuality when the underlying ethic, rightly understood, is not actually where the problem lies. The problem lies somewhere else, and the young person who left needs the church to be honest about where.

Here is the honest diagnosis. The church is losing people over sexuality not primarily because the biblical sexual ethic is too demanding, though it is, but because the church has paired that ethic with a set of ancillary commitments that are indefensible. The young person who walks away is often not walking away from the ethic. They are walking away from the package. The package includes purity culture, which damaged a generation. It includes political campaigns against the existence of gay people, which collapsed the distinction between the ethical question and the question of human dignity. It includes a pattern of protecting sexual predators in pulpits and ministry leadership, which told the watching world what the church actually cared about. It includes a view of the body as the enemy of the soul, which is not Christian but Platonic. It includes a view of women that, at its edges, treats them as sources of temptation to be managed rather than as image-bearers to be honored.

The package has to be disassembled before the ethic can be heard.

This chapter is going to try to do some of that disassembly.

Start with purity culture, because it is the most immediate source of pain for a significant portion of the deconstruction wave. Purity culture, as it was practiced in American evangelicalism from the 1990s into the 2010s, made promises it could not keep and inflicted damage it did not measure. It promised young women that their worth was located in their unbroken state and that God had a specific spouse waiting for them if they remained pure. It promised young men that they could control their lust through will power and accountability partners and that any failure was a moral catastrophe. It gave both groups a shared language of purity that treated sexual sin as uniquely defiling, worse than other sins, and that treated the sinner as damaged in a way that other sinners were not. It produced a generation of adults who entered marriage with wedding-night anxiety disorders, who carried shame about normal sexual desire as if the desire itself were the sin, and who, when the marriage faced the ordinary difficulties marriages face, did not have the theological vocabulary to locate themselves inside a larger grace.

The church has barely begun to reckon with what this did. The book that launched much of the movement, *I Kissed Dating Goodbye*, was eventually retracted by its own author, who now speaks publicly about the harm it caused and his own subsequent departure from the faith. That retraction should have been a moment of widespread institutional reflection. It was instead largely ignored by the leaders who had promoted the book, because institutional self-protection is the default instinct of institutions, and acknowledging that the movement did harm would cost too much. The young women who were told that their sexual history made them, in the analogy of the chewed gum or the used cup, permanently diminished, are now adult women. They have therapists. They have marriages that have required years of rebuilding. They have a generation of younger women watching them and asking whether the faith they were raised in can be trusted at all. The institution still has not apologized.

A pastor serious about his congregation should apologize, from

the pulpit, specifically, for what purity culture did. Not in general terms. Specifically. Name the teachings. Name the books. Name the conferences. Say, we held these things up and they hurt people. Here is what we got wrong. Here is what the biblical sexual ethic actually is, which is demanding but not shaming, and here is what your relationship to your own past looks like under grace. The confession does not surrender the ethic. It returns the ethic to its actual proportions and removes the ancillary claims that were never biblical in the first place. Young women, and young men, who heard the specific apology, might hear the whole gospel again for the first time in a decade.

Move to the harder ground. Homosexuality has been, for a generation, the question over which more deconstruction has happened than any other single question. It is worth asking why. The biblical position is not unclear. The historic teaching of the church, across Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant traditions, has been unanimous until very recently. The reasons for the teaching are not arbitrary. They emerge from a biblical anthropology in which the complementarity of male and female, the image of God borne together by humanity, and the creational pattern of marriage as a one-flesh union between a man and a woman, form a coherent framework that does not accommodate same-sex sexual union. I have argued this elsewhere and I will not repeat the argument here. What I want to say here is something different. It is that the way the church has carried the teaching has made the teaching unintelligible to a generation that is, in many ways, more morally serious than their elders. The teaching has been carried in ways that made it look like hatred, and the generation watching has filed it as hatred, and the church is now scrambling to explain that the teaching is not what the generation has filed.

Some of the responsibility lies with the surrounding culture, which has done significant work to make any traditional sexual ethic look like bigotry. I will give that point its due. But most of the responsibility lies with the church itself. The church spent thirty

years, from roughly 1980 to 2010, putting enormous political energy into fighting public accommodations for gay people, arguing against the decriminalization of homosexuality and then against civil unions and then against marriage equality, while doing comparatively little to articulate a positive vision of singleness, chastity, friendship, and the moral life of the body. The priorities were lopsided. The lopsidedness told the watching world, and the young people in the church's own pews, that the church cared more about the political containment of gay people than about the spiritual formation of anyone. The message was received.

It did not have to be this way. The church could have held the traditional teaching privately while refusing to make public-policy enforcement of that teaching its central political cause. It could have modeled singleness as a vocation rather than as a failure state. It could have welcomed gay people into congregations as full participants in the life of the church, called to the same holiness as everyone else, in the same way that single heterosexual Christians have always been called. It could have developed a theology of friendship robust enough to bear the weight that friendship carries in a church where celibacy is a real vocation. It did none of these things, or did them only in small corners. It chose, instead, political campaign work. The bill came due.

To the young person who has deconstructed over this issue, I want to say several things that may be uncomfortable for both of us. First, the ethic itself, after you have stripped away the political baggage, is not indefensible. It emerges from a biblical anthropology that is richer than the caricatures you have been handed. Read Wesley Hill's *Washed and Waiting*. Read Eve Tushnet. Read Wesley Hill's own work on spiritual friendship. These are gay Christians who have held to the traditional teaching and who have articulated what that looks like in ways that the political combatants in both camps have not. You can disagree with them at the end. You cannot say the position has no defenders who have lived inside it with integrity. That position exists. It deserves a hearing.

Second, the way the question got litigated in public, as if the only options were full cultural affirmation and total exclusion, was not the only option. The church has options inside its own life that the culture war did not allow to develop. The question is not whether the church will bless gay marriage. The question is whether the church can be a place where a gay Christian who holds to a traditional sexual ethic can find community, friendship, vocational meaning, and full participation in the life of the congregation, or whether the church will be a place that implicitly or explicitly tells that Christian to go somewhere else. The first is possible. The second is sin. Most American evangelical churches have defaulted to the second by omission, not by design, but the omission is not innocent.

Third, the way the church has treated gay people who are not Christians has done enormous damage to the gospel's public witness. The young person who watched their gay uncle ostracized by the Christian relatives, who watched the conservative church lobby against their gay friend's adoption rights, who heard the joke from the pulpit about the transgender person, has file cabinets full of evidence that the church is not, at least not for gay people, a place of grace. The young person cannot unsee that evidence. The church that wants the young person to reconsider its position on the ethic has to first repent of the evidence. Not spin. Not reframing. Repentance. The specific acknowledgment that the behavior was wrong, that the lobbying did not need to happen in the way it happened, that the joke was cruel, that the uncle should have been at the table. That repentance is the precondition for any further conversation, and most churches have not offered it.

Fourth, transgender questions have entered the church's attention with extraordinary speed, and most churches do not yet have the theological or pastoral resources to engage them well. There are things that can be said. Bodies are meaningful. The male-female distinction is not incidental to the human person. The Christian tradition has resources for honoring the body without treating the body's givenness as a cage. There are also things that have to be said

about the limits of the church's wisdom here. The phenomenon of rapid-onset gender dysphoria among adolescent girls, which has produced a surge of medical interventions whose long-term outcomes are poorly understood, is a different question than the question of adult transsexuals who have lived in a transitioned identity for decades. The church that flattens all of these into a single ideological target has not done the work the question requires. The church that uncritically accepts every affirmation claim and shrugs off the serious moral and medical concerns has also not done the work. The work is harder than either tribal position allows.

A serious pastoral posture on transgender questions will, I think, have a few features. It will insist that every person who experiences gender dysphoria is an image-bearer, not a symbol of cultural corruption or a battleground in a culture war. It will decline to adopt either the progressive position that medical intervention is always the right answer or the reactive position that gender dysphoria is always a delusion or a perversion. It will take seriously the empirical data on outcomes, which is not as settled as either side pretends. It will be pastoral with individual people while teaching the theological anthropology of the body with clarity. It will not, I think, bless medical interventions on minors, because the evidence on adolescent outcomes is genuinely concerning and because the church has a particular duty to protect children from irreversible decisions. It will make room for adults who have transitioned and who are now Christians, without requiring of them a specific path back that the Scripture itself does not specify. It will be gentle with families in crisis. It will be patient.

This pastoral posture is going to disappoint the loudest voices in the culture war. The progressive voices will say it is not affirming enough. The reactive voices will say it is too accommodating. The pastoral posture is not trying to win the culture war. It is trying to minister to the actual human beings who are suffering in front of it, while holding to the anthropology that the faith has always taught, and doing so with the humility that the actual complexity of the

questions requires. That posture is harder than either political alternative. It is also the only one a serious pastor can hold for long.

The deeper issue in all of this, the one that feeds every individual question, is the church's anthropology of the body. Too much American evangelicalism, for too long, has operated with a functional anthropology that was more gnostic than Christian. It treated the body as a source of problems. It treated desire as contamination. It treated sexuality as, at best, a necessary evil sanctified by marriage. This anthropology is not biblical. The Bible teaches that the body is good, that it was made good, that it was made for pleasure as well as for labor and reproduction, that it will be resurrected, and that the Christian ethic of sexuality is an ethic of honoring the body's design rather than fearing the body's power.

The sexual ethic of the Bible is demanding because it takes bodies seriously, not because it despises them. Chastity outside of marriage is a call to honor the body by refusing to use it, or to be used, for purposes that the covenantal framework of sexual union was not made to bear. Fidelity within marriage is a call to honor the body of the other as a gift rather than a possession. The ethic is exalted, not reductive. When it has been preached reductively, as a set of shaming rules and a management regime for desire, it has been preached as something other than what the Bible offers.

A congregation that recovers a biblical anthropology of the body will be unrecognizable to a congregation shaped by purity culture. It will be a congregation in which children are told that their bodies are good, that growing up is not embarrassing, that sexual desire is not a sign of spiritual failure. It will be a congregation in which the single adults are not pitied as incomplete. It will be a congregation in which married couples speak about sex in ways that are neither puritanical nor crass, as a real and good part of the covenant they are living. It will be a congregation in which the gay member is not a category to be managed but a brother or sister whose call to holiness is the same as everyone else's, held inside a community that has thought hard about what friendship, hospitality, and family mean for every

member. It will be a congregation in which the person who has made a mess of their sexuality is not consigned to the margins but met with the same grace that was extended to David, to the Samaritan woman, to the Corinthians.

This is the congregation the young person has been looking for. When they cannot find it, they leave. When they can find it, they stay, and sometimes they come back. The ethic they resented was, in many cases, the caricature of the ethic. The actual ethic, held inside a congregation that treats bodies well, is not an instrument of oppression. It is a path, hard but not impossible, toward a life that is more fully human. The young person who has heard the caricature has not heard the thing itself. They can still be offered the thing itself.

Let me close the chapter with a confession. I have gotten things wrong in this area. I preached sermons, early in my ministry, that were more shaped by purity culture than by the biblical anthropology I now believe. I gave counsel to young people that, in retrospect, did more harm than good. I spent years absorbing a framework that I have had to work to unlearn. I am still unlearning. I do not pretend to have arrived. What I can say is that I have tried, in the last several years, to preach the goodness of the body, the dignity of desire, the exalted demandingness of the biblical ethic, and the grace that meets us inside all of our failures with it. That preaching has met with relief in my congregation. Several people have told me, after services, that they heard something they had been waiting most of their lives to hear. They had been told the rules without being told the anthropology. They had been told to hate their desire without being told what their desire was for. They had been told that their body was dangerous without being told that it was a gift. Hearing the gift changed everything.

You can hear it too. The faith that frightened you with its rules is still there for you, but the version of the faith that frightened you with its rules was not the faith itself. The faith is larger. The faith is kinder. The faith takes your body more seriously, not less seriously, than the cultural alternatives. The faith asks more of you. The asking is part of

the gift. The gift is yours.

CHAPTER 13

The Spiritual Abuse Reckoning

There is a category of deconstruction that does not begin with doctrinal questions or with cultural discomfort or with the ordinary friction of religious life. It begins with a specific person, in a specific position of spiritual authority, who used that authority to harm a specific victim. The harm may have been sexual. It may have been financial. It may have been the slower and less visible harm of coercion, control, humiliation, and shame. It may have been perpetrated by the person and covered over by the institution. The victim walks out of that room changed. The faith they were taught inside that room is now tangled with the memory of what happened inside that room. Pulling them apart is the work of years.

A book on deconstruction that does not take this category seriously is not a serious book. I want to take it seriously here, even though the chapter will be harder to write than the others and harder to read. The phenomenon of spiritual abuse is not rare. It has happened in the largest evangelical networks in America. It has happened in Catholic institutions across continents. It has happened in small rural churches nobody has ever heard of. It has happened to men and women and children. It has been perpetrated by people who held themselves out as servants of Christ. It has been, at many points in the church's history, institutionally protected. The scale is massive. The damage is generational. Any pastoral response to the deconstruction wave that does not begin from an honest accounting of the abuse crisis is not a response, it is a cope.

Start with definitions. Spiritual abuse, as the scholarly literature on the phenomenon uses the term, is the use of spiritual authority to control, coerce, manipulate, or harm another person. It includes obvious forms, like pastoral sexual abuse, financial exploitation, and

physical violence by clergy or clergy-adjacent leaders. It also includes less obvious forms. Shaming people in front of the congregation for disagreeing with the pastor. Weaponizing the membership covenant to punish dissent. Using the language of submission to silence victims. Deploying spiritual language to bypass ordinary ethical analysis, as in, God has told me you need to do this, so the fact that it looks wrong is just your lack of faith. Coaching spouses to forgive abusers without any corresponding accountability for the abuser. Telling abuse victims they need to examine their own contribution to the abuse. Each of these is a form of spiritual abuse even when it does not rise to the level of a criminal offense.

The harm done by spiritual abuse is distinctive. It is not merely the harm of the abuse itself, which would be sufficient to ruin a life. It is the harm of the abuse being inflicted in the name of God, using the language of God, by a representative of God. The victim cannot separate the abuser from the faith. Their spiritual imagination has been colonized. Prayer feels like manipulation, because manipulation was called prayer. Scripture feels like a weapon, because scripture was used as a weapon. Worship feels dangerous, because the abuser led worship. The body carries the memory of what was done in churches, and the body recoils when it sees a church, hears a sermon, encounters a verse. This is not a failure of faith. This is the normal response of a human organism to trauma. Expecting the victim to overcome it by force of will is cruel.

The victim of spiritual abuse who decides that the Christian faith is finally not credible has been given enormous reasons to decide that. The question for the serious pastor is not whether those reasons are sufficient. The question is whether the church has responded to those reasons the way it should have. The answer, in most cases, is that it has not.

Consider the institutional patterns. When a pastor is credibly accused of sexual misconduct, the pattern of the institution is almost always to delay. To convene a committee. To consult lawyers. To ask whether there is enough for a lawsuit. To weigh the reputational

exposure. To urge the victim to consider reconciliation. To suggest that going public would hurt the church's mission. To encourage silence. To offer a severance package with a non-disclosure agreement. To allow the pastor to resign with a face-saving letter. To decline to inform other churches where the pastor might seek to be hired. This pattern is not a feature of specific denominations or specific networks. It is a feature of the institution itself. Every human institution, when exposed to the possibility of a sexual scandal, instinctively prioritizes its own survival over the vulnerable. The church is not an exception. The church that claimed to be held to a higher standard has failed the standard as predictably as every other institution has.

The public cases that have shaped the deconstruction wave are names the reader knows. Ravi Zacharias, whose decades of apologetics ministry covered decades of sexual predation that the institution he built knew about or should have known about. Bill Hybels, whose Willow Creek megachurch spent years absorbing and denying credible allegations. The Southern Baptist Convention, whose 2022 investigation revealed a pattern of institutional cover-up across hundreds of cases. Individual pastors in every major network whose names became cautionary tales for a generation of young Christians who watched the reveals in real time and watched the institutional responses and drew conclusions.

The conclusions the young person drew were not conclusions about individual failures. They were conclusions about institutional character. They concluded that the evangelical church, as an institution, cannot be trusted with power over the vulnerable. They concluded that the church's public moralism was a cover for private predation. They concluded that the men in charge were willing to sacrifice the people they were supposed to protect in order to maintain their positions. They concluded, in short, that the institution was not what it had claimed to be, and that the claims themselves were therefore suspect.

You can argue that the conclusion overgeneralizes. You can point

out the faithful pastors and the healthy congregations that do not fit the pattern. These arguments are not false. But they do not answer the deeper question, which is whether the institution that produced the failures is capable of the reforms that would prevent their recurrence, and whether the institution is telling the truth about the failures it has acknowledged. On both questions, the evidence is mixed at best. The Southern Baptist response to its own investigation was slower and weaker than the investigation's findings warranted. The accountability structures that were proposed have mostly not been implemented. The independent oversight that would require the institution to accept limits on its own authority has been resisted. The young person who watches these developments knows what she is watching. She is watching an institution that knows it has failed, knows it needs to change, and is nonetheless choosing, at the moment of decision, to protect itself rather than protect the vulnerable.

What can a pastor in a local church do, given that the national patterns are beyond his direct control?

First, name the crisis, from the pulpit, in specific terms. Do not speak in generalities. Say the names of the institutions that have failed. Say the patterns by which they failed. Say that the failures are the reason some of your congregation's children have left the faith. Do not soften the saying. The young person in the room needs to hear, from the pulpit, that the person in the pulpit sees what they see. That hearing is the precondition for everything else.

Second, implement concrete accountability structures in your own congregation. Background checks on every person in children's ministry and youth ministry. Two-adult rules without exception. A credible process for reporting concerns that does not route through the pastor who is potentially the problem. A relationship with outside trauma-informed counselors. A written policy on how allegations will be handled, with a bias toward believing the vulnerable and a commitment to involve civil authorities in cases of suspected crimes. A willingness to share information with other congregations when a leader leaves under concerning circumstances rather than wrapping

the departure in confidentiality. These structures are not signs of cynicism. They are signs of humility. They are the institution admitting that it cannot trust itself and therefore needs systems that do not depend on the goodness of any individual.

Third, develop a pastoral theology of trauma that is adequate to what the victim is carrying. A victim of spiritual abuse does not need to be told to pray harder. She needs to be referred to a trauma-informed therapist, and she needs that therapist to be financially accessible. She needs a congregation that can sit with her through the slow work of healing, without timelines, without pressure to produce the expected spiritual breakthroughs. She needs the church to be willing to say, we were part of the system that hurt you, even if you and I were not the specific actors, and we are sorry. She needs permission to have a complicated relationship with prayer, with worship, with Scripture, for as long as that complexity takes to resolve. She needs to know that her return to the faith, if it happens, will not be required to follow the schedule the congregation would prefer. The church that can offer these things is a church that has a chance of keeping her. The church that cannot will lose her, and will lose her permanently.

Fourth, do not defend the indefensible. When a major evangelical figure falls, and the fall is confirmed, do not construct elaborate rationalizations for why the fallen figure's teaching can still be relied on. Do not suggest that his accusers had political motives. Do not deflect to the sins of progressive Christians as if the comparison excused the failure. Confess it. Say it cost the church dearly. Say the institution's response fell short. Say what needs to change. Do this even if it costs you friendships with other pastors who are still in the defensive crouch. The young person in your congregation is listening. The single word that restores her faith may be your willingness to say something true about a man who shook your hand at the conference last year.

Fifth, teach a doctrine of authority that does not make pastors or elders into figures beyond challenge. The New Testament model of

eldership is plural, accountable, and servant-shaped. It is not monarchical. Paul expected elders to be corrected. Peter rebuked apostles. The congregation was not passive material for the leaders to shape. It was a body that carried the Spirit and was capable, under the Spirit, of discerning when its leaders had gone wrong. Restoring this ecclesiology is not a concession to modern egalitarianism. It is a return to what the New Testament actually teaches, and it is the structural precondition for any church that will not repeat the abuses it is confessing.

A word to the abuse victim, if you are reading this. I do not presume to speak for what you have carried. I do not presume that the words on this page can do anything for you that the presence of a human being could not do better. What I can say is that your instincts are trustworthy. The wrongness you felt was real wrongness. The silence that surrounded the wrongness was a second injury. The institution that failed to protect you failed the God it claimed to serve, not the other way around. Your faith, or what remains of it, is not on trial in this matter. The institution is. If you have left the church because you could not stay inside the institution that hurt you, you are not a failure. You are an accurate observer of the world that was presented to you. What you do next is not something I will prescribe from a distance. I will only say that there are Christians, and Christian communities, that have been doing the slow work of not being like the institution that hurt you. Some of them are trustworthy. Some of them are not yet. Trust slowly. Trust specifically. Trust people, not logos. The Spirit moves where it wills. It can reach you again, when and if you are ready, through a human being who is safe. Until then, the grief you carry is not a sign of failed faith. It is a sign that what happened to you mattered, that you are not willing to pretend it did not happen, and that the God you may or may not still believe in has the same posture about it. He is not pleased. He is not on the side of the institution. He is on your side, and has been, and has grieved what you have grieved.

A final note, for the pastor reading this who is not a victim but

who has proximity to the culture that produces abuse. Examine your own habits. Are you running a personality cult without knowing it? Are there people in your congregation who are afraid to disagree with you? Do you surround yourself with yes-men? Do the staff meetings have any real disagreement, or does disagreement get punished and then slowly disappear? Do you have accountability relationships that are actually accountable, or are they with men who owe you favors and will not push you when it counts? The abusive pastor is not, in most cases, a monster who entered ministry to hurt people. He is, in most cases, a man who started with real convictions and then, over decades, allowed the small compromises of power to add up, unchallenged, until the compromises were the whole person. You are not immune. I am not immune. The guardrails are the point. Install them. Trust them. Let them do their work.

The spiritual abuse reckoning is not over. It is not even close to over. The investigations that have reshaped the Southern Baptist Convention will reshape other networks in the coming decade, because the pattern is not unique to the SBC, it is unique to institutions run by men with power. The church that wants to be trustworthy again has to be willing to face what is coming, to confess what is surfacing, to protect the vulnerable without exception, and to accept that its credibility will be rebuilt only over a generation, not a news cycle. That work is possible. It is not comfortable. It is what the faith itself calls for, and it is what the young person who has watched the failures is waiting to see. Not more statements. Not more branding. Structural change, sustained through the slow years, visible in the policies, verifiable in the practice. That is the work. It is the only work that will hold.

CHAPTER 14

Doubt as Devotion: A Theology of Not Knowing

The deconstruction wave has made one contribution to American Christian life that is worth naming as a gift, not a threat. It has forced the church to talk about doubt in ways the church has mostly refused to talk about it. For a generation, American evangelical preaching treated doubt as a problem to be solved, a weakness to be confessed, a symptom of a life not fully surrendered. The doubters sat in the pews listening to sermons about the doubters as if the doubters were an outside population. They learned to hide. They learned to say amen when they did not feel amen. They learned to sing songs of confident faith when they did not have confident faith. They learned to perform belief in order to remain acceptable. The performance was not sustainable. When it broke, the breaking looked like apostasy, but it was not apostasy. It was the end of the performance.

This chapter will argue that doubt, rightly understood, is not the opposite of faith. It is often the form faith takes in a mind that is thinking. The Bible itself gives us this, repeatedly, if we have the eyes to see it. The psalms of lament are doubt made liturgical. Habakkuk is doubt made prophetic. Job is doubt made dramatic. Ecclesiastes is doubt made aphoristic. The Gospel of Mark ends, in its earliest manuscripts, with the women fleeing the empty tomb in fear, saying nothing to anyone. That is the ending the earliest church preserved, the ending that made it into the earliest copies of the Gospel. The first response to the resurrection, as the first Christians told the story, was fear and silence. Faith came later. Faith has always come later. The church that has not told this story has told a different story, and the different story has cost it.

Let me work the psalms first, because they are the place where the church has the most room to recover the theology of doubt it has lost.

The book of Psalms is the prayer book of the people of God. It was the prayer book of Jesus. It is, at a conservative estimate, one-third complaint and one-third lament. The singers of these psalms are not theological novices, not weak faith, not people who needed to have their doubt corrected by a confident senior saint. They are the core of the worshiping tradition, and the core of the worshiping tradition spent a significant portion of its praying life in complaint. Read Psalm 13. How long, O Lord. Will you forget me forever. How long will you hide your face from me. That is not a warm-up to the real faith. That is the faith. The psalmist is doing faith by speaking this complaint to the God he does not currently feel is listening. The faith is not located in the feeling. The faith is located in the act of address. He is still talking to God, even when he is telling God that God has failed him. That is what faith looks like in the dark.

A church that cannot pray Psalm 13 without editing it has not understood the faith it claims to have inherited. A church that skips the laments in its worship services, or softens them into generic confessions of struggle, has taken away from its people the prayer language they need most when they need any prayer at all. The deconstructor who was told to stop doubting and start trusting was given advice that the psalmist would not recognize. The psalmist trusts by doubting out loud in the presence of the One he doubts. That is the model. When the church has lost the model, its people do not know how to stay in relationship with God through the seasons of darkness, because they have never been taught that relationship includes darkness.

Habakkuk goes further. The prophet opens his book with a complaint to God that God is not doing anything about the injustice in Judah. God responds, eventually, by saying that he is going to do something, which is to bring the Babylonians to sack the country. Habakkuk's response to that answer is a second complaint, longer and more specific than the first. You are going to use the Babylonians to

discipline us. But the Babylonians are worse than we are. How can the holy one use the unholy as his instrument. The prophet holds this question, unresolved, through much of the book. God's answer is not a refutation of the question. God's answer is a promise that the righteous will live by faith, and a theophany in which God's character is displayed as worth trusting even when the mechanisms are unclear. At the end of the book Habakkuk says, though the fig tree does not blossom and no fruit is on the vine, though the labor of the olive fails and the fields yield no food, yet I will rejoice in the Lord. That is not a resolution of the question. That is a decision, made inside the unresolved question, to continue trusting the character of the God whose ways remain mysterious. The question is not answered. The prophet is answered.

This is what mature faith often looks like in the Bible. It is not faith without questions. It is faith inside the questions, making its decisions about trust based on the character of the God it knows from the history of God's dealings, even when the current dealing does not make sense. The deconstructor who was told that faith required the absence of questions has been given a simulation of faith, not the thing itself. The actual thing is more rugged and more textured. It survives hard questions because it was built for them.

Job is another case. The book spends thirty-seven chapters on dialogue between Job and his comforters, in which the comforters advocate a theological system that Job refuses to accept. Job refuses because the system does not match his experience, and because the system requires him to confess sins he did not commit in order to rescue God's reputation. Job declines the rescue. God, at the end of the book, vindicates Job against the comforters, saying they have not spoken of me what is right as my servant Job has. Think about that. The comforters had the doctrinally correct theology of retribution, that suffering comes from sin. Job rejected it. God sided with Job. The lesson is not that Job was theologically sophisticated. Job himself admits he did not know everything. The lesson is that God prefers the honest complaint that refuses to explain God to the

dishonest piety that protects a theological system at the cost of truth.

The contemporary American evangelical church is full of comforters. It is full of people who will assure the doubter that God has a plan, that everything will work out, that the suffering is producing character, that the doubter just needs to trust. These comforters are not always wrong. Sometimes they are right. But when they are right, they are right accidentally, because their method is wrong. Their method is to defend God's reputation by explaining God's ways, when the book of Job is on record as saying that method is exactly what offends God. God does not need to be defended by explanations that the doubter experiences as lies. God prefers, according to Job, the truthful complaint that leaves the question open.

Now, a pastoral note, because I do not want to suggest that every expression of doubt is automatically legitimate faith. Some doubt is intellectual laziness. Some doubt is a mask for something else, for moral resistance to teachings the doubter does not want to obey, for cultural pressure that the doubter has not interrogated. Faithful pastoral work distinguishes between the doubt that is seeking truth and the doubt that is avoiding it. The distinction is not always easy to make, and pastors err regularly in both directions. The pastor who calls every doubt legitimate has flattened the category and will not help the person who actually needs to be challenged. The pastor who calls every doubt illegitimate has absolutized the category and will crush the person who needs to be received.

The test, when you are trying to tell the difference, is not primarily doctrinal. It is postural. The doubter who is seeking truth keeps showing up, keeps asking, keeps reading, keeps praying in the half-light. The doubter who is avoiding truth stops showing up, stops asking, stops reading, stops praying, and reaches instead for the lifestyle options the doubt has opened. Both of these may use the same vocabulary of deconstruction. They are in fact different phenomena. The first is faith in process. The second is something else. A good pastor pays attention to which one is in front of him, and responds accordingly. The first needs companionship. The second

needs a loving confrontation.

I want to spend some time on the category of dark night of the soul, because it has entered contemporary Christian conversation with less precision than it deserves. The term comes from the sixteenth-century Spanish mystic John of the Cross, who wrote about a specific spiritual experience in which God, he argued, withdraws the emotional consolations of faith in order to purify the believer's attachment. The dark night is not the same as doubt, though it can look like doubt from the inside. It is an experience of aridity, of silence from the divine side, of prayer that feels like nothing, of the loss of felt presence. The mystics who wrote about it, John of the Cross and Teresa of Avila and Thomas Merton and others, insisted that this condition, unpleasant as it is, is often a sign of spiritual progress rather than regression. The believer is being weaned from reliance on the emotional by-products of faith so that she can come to rest in the God who is there even when the emotional by-products are absent.

This category, if it is present in your congregation's vocabulary at all, is a gift you can give to a certain kind of deconstructor. The person who says, I used to feel God's presence and now I feel nothing, and therefore I must have lost the faith, is often the person who is, in fact, in a dark night. The felt presence was never the faith. The felt presence was a gracious support that God gives to new believers and sometimes takes away from maturing ones. The absence of the felt presence does not indicate the absence of God. It can indicate, in some cases, a deepening of the relationship that is now being asked to grow up into something less dependent on felt reassurance. Mother Teresa lived most of her adult life in this condition. The letters she left behind, published after her death, show a woman who worked among the dying in Calcutta for five decades while feeling nothing whatsoever of the God she was serving. Her superiors, when she confided this to them, affirmed her by saying the condition was consistent with her calling, and that the service itself was the faith. She continued. The continuation was faith.

This resource is available to your congregation. The dark night is not a fringe topic. It is mainstream Christian spirituality, attested across centuries, across traditions, across individuals whose lives bear the marks of deep faith. Teach it. Name it. Let your congregation know that the felt absence of God, inside a continuing commitment to God, is not a sign of spiritual failure. It is one of the ways mature faith can look. The deconstructor in your pew who has been assuming that lost feeling means lost faith may, on hearing this, realize that she has been inside a classical Christian experience that she did not know had a name.

Let me sketch what a theology of doubt might look like, as a positive proposal rather than only as a corrective.

A theology of doubt starts with the recognition that God is greater than the mind's capacity to comprehend him. This is not evasion. It is one of the oldest confessions of the Christian tradition. God is not an object in the universe, accessible to inventory the way a chair or a planet would be. God is the ground of being, the source from which all finite things come, the mystery at the center of existence. Talk about God is always partial, always analogical, always bounded by the limits of the creaturely mind attempting it. Doubt, honestly confronted, is often the creaturely mind encountering its limits and being appropriately humbled by them. That encounter is closer to worship than to apostasy.

A theology of doubt continues with the recognition that Scripture itself contains the doubting voices and honors them. Job. Ecclesiastes. The laments. The honest anger of Jeremiah, who accused God of seduction. The confused silence of the disciples after the crucifixion. The cry of dereliction from the cross itself. My God my God why have you forsaken me. This is not decoration on the Bible. It is the center of the Bible. The center of the Christian faith is a moment of the Son asking the Father a question that is never answered in the text. The answer is not given. The answer is embodied, three days later, in the resurrection. But the question stands. The Christian tradition has always, at its best, held the

question as part of the faith. The traditions that have erased the question have given their people a lighter faith, but the lighter faith does not survive the hard night. The heavier faith, which carries the question with it, does.

A theology of doubt finally grounds itself in the person of Jesus Christ. The doubter is not asked to believe a system. The doubter is asked to continue looking at Jesus, in the Gospels, and to say what the doubter actually sees. If Jesus, after a long look, still compels, then the doubter still has a faith, even if every doctrinal position the doubter once held is now in motion. Faith in Christ is more durable than faith in the system that has interpreted Christ. The system has often been wrong. Christ remains. The doubter who has lost confidence in the system and still cannot stop looking at Christ is not a failed believer. She is, in some ways, more clearly a believer than many who have confidence in the system but have not looked at Christ in years.

What does the pastor do with all of this, practically? A few things.

First, preach the doubting Scriptures. Spend a sermon series on the psalms of lament. Preach through Job, not just the punchline at the end but the whole architecture of the dialogue. Preach Habakkuk. Preach the cry of dereliction. Let your congregation hear, from the pulpit, that the faith they inherited has always included these voices, and that the voices are part of the faith, not a departure from it.

Second, make space in your congregation for expressed doubt. Have conversations in small groups that are structured around the questions rather than around the approved answers. Train lay leaders in how to host those conversations without defensiveness. Let the doubter experience, in a Christian setting, that the question she thought would get her exiled is actually received as a legitimate form of inquiry. That experience alone can restore years of lost trust.

Third, do not rush the resolution. The doubter is on a schedule that is not yours. Some questions take decades to settle, and some questions are never settled on this side. The faithful stance toward the

doubter is patience. The church that expected every question to resolve by next Tuesday has failed many doubters. The church that can walk with the doubter for five years without pressuring resolution has a chance of keeping her.

Fourth, model your own doubt, within limits. The pastor who pretends to have never doubted anything is not credible and is not imitating any saint in church history. The pastor who shares selectively from his own experience of aridity, confusion, and unresolved question gives his congregation permission to have the same experiences. The sharing has to be discerning. The pulpit is not the place to process your current crisis. But the pulpit is the place to tell the congregation, truthfully, that faith has seasons and you have walked through some of them, and that the God who met you in the dark is the God you continue to trust even when you do not feel him.

Fifth, tell the doubter, out loud, that her continued presence in the congregation is not contingent on arriving at specific conclusions by specific dates. Tell her the congregation will be honored by her presence whether she ever fully resolves her questions or not. Tell her that the church is not a fraternity requiring agreement on a password. It is a family that loves its members through whatever they are carrying. This telling, alone, can keep her for years. The lack of this telling will, predictably, lose her.

The church that learns to honor doubt will not be a church of doubters. It will be a church of people whose faith has been tested and who have remained. The testing is not a bug. The testing is how faith grows up. The smooth, untested faith that has never considered the hard questions is a brittle faith. It shatters on impact. The weathered faith that has held the questions for years, prayed through the dark nights, accepted the limits of its own understanding, and continued anyway, is the faith that can sustain a life. That is the faith the deconstructor is looking for. Most of them will not say that is what they are looking for. Most of them will say they are looking for honesty, or for a church that is not afraid of their questions, or for a space where they can breathe. These are the same thing, described

from the outside. Offer it. The ones who can be kept, will be kept.

CHAPTER 15

Reconstruction: What Faith Looks Like on the Other Side

The word deconstruction has dominated the conversation so completely that the other word, reconstruction, has barely found its footing. That is a problem, because deconstruction on its own is a half-process. Pulling something apart without knowing how to put anything together is not a destination. It is a stalled engine. A significant portion of the deconstruction wave has stalled there, not because the people involved did not want to move forward but because nobody gave them a map and the map they had been handed only described the demolition. What does faith look like on the other side of the deconstruction? That is the question this chapter will try to answer, knowing that the answer is different for different people and knowing that the answer requires some courage from the reader.

Start with the recognition that not every deconstruction produces the same outcome. A taxonomy is useful. Some people who deconstruct end up as atheists or agnostics. They have concluded that the supernatural framework itself does not survive scrutiny, and they have built lives inside a secular frame that they find adequate. I am not writing this chapter primarily to them, though some of them read books like this and I am glad when they do. Some people who deconstruct end up in a kind of spiritual-but-not-religious floating state, in which they retain vague convictions about meaning and the transcendent but have no ecclesial home. This is the modal outcome for American deconstructors, statistically, and it is a precarious place to live long-term because it leaves the person without community, without practice, and without a tradition to push back against their own drift. Some people who deconstruct end up in a different

Christian tradition than the one they left. The evangelical who becomes Anglican. The evangelical who becomes Catholic. The evangelical who becomes Orthodox. The evangelical who becomes a progressive mainline Protestant. These moves have their own dynamics and their own risks, but they preserve the Christian framework while restructuring its practice. Some people who deconstruct end up back inside a recognizable evangelicalism, but with a different posture, having sorted through what they needed to sort through. This chapter is mostly written for the last three categories, and especially for people in the middle ones who have not yet found a stable home.

Here is what I think the reconstructive work looks like, when it goes well.

The first piece is the recovery of the Great Tradition. What I mean by the Great Tradition is the broad stream of Christian thought and practice that predates the modern period and that is the shared inheritance of Catholics, Orthodox, and historic Protestants. The Apostles' Creed. The Nicene Creed. The seven ecumenical councils. The liturgical year. The sacraments. The spiritual disciplines of prayer, fasting, silence, and Scripture meditation that the church has practiced, in various forms, since its earliest centuries. Many American evangelical deconstructors have never been introduced to this tradition at all. They assume that American evangelicalism is Christianity, and that when they have rejected American evangelicalism, they have rejected the whole thing. This assumption is historically ignorant. American evangelicalism, as it exists today, is a relatively recent cultural formation, two hundred years old in its earliest forms and in its current shape only several decades old. The Great Tradition is two thousand years old and will outlast the current American formation, which is, on the evidence, in advanced decomposition. The deconstructor who has never been given the resources of the Great Tradition has rejected a slice of Christianity while assuming they have rejected all of it. They have not. The rest is still available, and it is often deeper, stranger, richer, and more

durable than the slice they left.

Begin, then, by reading the Great Tradition. Read Augustine's Confessions. Read Athanasius on the incarnation. Read Julian of Norwich. Read Bonaventure. Read Thomas Aquinas, at least in summary. Read the Philokalia from the Orthodox tradition. Read Thomas à Kempis. Read George Herbert. Read Bonhoeffer. Read Marilynne Robinson. These are not extras. These are the spine of the faith you may have thought you left, and they are still here, patient, waiting for you to notice them. You may find, in reading them, that many of the questions that made evangelicalism unsupportable for you are not questions these writers share. They lived inside a faith that had different loads on it, different emphases, different habits. Their Christianity is recognizably continuous with yours, but it is not identical to the one that exhausted you. That discovery alone can reopen the possibility of faith.

The second piece is the recovery of practice. American evangelicalism has, over the last century, tended to reduce the Christian life to belief plus affect. You have to believe the right propositions, and you have to feel the right emotions about Jesus. That reduction has left generations of Christians without a practice of faith that can hold them when the beliefs get complicated and the feelings dry up. The Great Tradition, by contrast, has always held faith together with practice. You pray the daily office. You fast on specified days. You observe the liturgical year. You participate in the sacraments. You engage in acts of corporal mercy. You practice hospitality. You are formed by what you do, not only by what you think. The formation is the point. Belief is sustained by practice more than by argument. A practice of regular prayer, practiced over years, forms a person who finds God in the practice itself, even when the beliefs are in motion.

The deconstructor who is looking for something that will hold her does not need, first, a better apologetic. She needs a practice. She needs to be given, by a trustworthy spiritual director or pastor or friend, a short list of practices and told, do these, for a year, without

worrying about whether you believe them. Pray the Lord's Prayer every morning. Read one psalm a day. Take communion weekly if you can find a church that will let you, even if you are not sure you believe everything that goes with it. Sabbath one day a week. Give ten percent of your income to causes you respect. Volunteer, consistently, at one institution that serves the vulnerable in your city. Practice confession, to one trusted human being, of your real sins, not the generic ones. These practices, sustained, will change the person doing them. They will also, over time, do something to the beliefs that sit above them. The beliefs will clarify. Some will fall away. Some will deepen. The process will not follow the timeline of the person's impatience. It will follow the timeline of the practice itself. This is how the faith has worked for most of its history. Recovering it is recovering something almost everyone in modern Christianity has lost.

The third piece is the recovery of a communal frame. Christianity is not a private enterprise. It has always been, at its core, a communal faith, and the attempts to practice it privately have generally failed. The deconstructor who is looking for a reconstruction that will hold will, sooner or later, have to find a community. This is difficult because the community they came from is often the thing they have been processing. It is difficult because the alternatives often look off-putting, either too conservative or too progressive or too formal or too casual. It is difficult because finding a church in an unfamiliar tradition is uncomfortable. It is necessary anyway. You cannot reconstruct the faith alone in your kitchen. You need other bodies in a room, praying and singing and serving with you, over years, for the practice to become the person.

The community you find does not have to be the community you end in. Many people on the reconstructive path have gone through several congregations before they settled. A deconstructor who experiments with an Anglican parish, finds it useful for a season, then tries a Catholic mass, finds it more than she expected, then lands in a liturgical Lutheran congregation that fits her, has not been unstable.

She has been searching with discernment, and discernment takes time. The only mistake is giving up. The person who tries one church, finds it imperfect, and concludes that church is not for them, has not been sufficiently patient with the process. Every church is imperfect. The question is not whether the imperfection exists but whether the community, as a whole, is one in which your reconstruction can proceed. Pay attention. Stay when staying is productive. Leave when leaving is necessary. Do not confuse discomfort with incompatibility. Much of the work of reconstruction requires sitting through discomfort.

The fourth piece is the recovery of an intellectual architecture that can hold the actual complexity of the questions you have been asking. American evangelicalism, in its mainstream form, tends to operate with a fairly thin intellectual toolkit. You are given a few simple frames that are supposed to handle everything. Worldview apologetics. Proof texts. A small canon of authorized thinkers, all of whom are broadly in agreement. When the questions get larger, the toolkit gives out. The deconstructor, at that point, often assumes the faith itself has run out of resources. It has not. The faith has vast resources. The deconstructor has been operating inside a small subset.

To expand the toolkit, read outside the subset. Read the Catholic philosophers, Alasdair MacIntyre, Charles Taylor, James K. A. Smith. Read the Orthodox theologians, John Zizioulas, David Bentley Hart, Frederica Mathewes-Green. Read the mainline Protestant heavyweights, Karl Barth, Dietrich Bonhoeffer, Stanley Hauerwas, Fleming Rutledge. Read the contemporary evangelicals who are doing the intellectual work seriously, N. T. Wright, Richard Hays, Miroslav Volf, Esau McCaulley. These writers will not all agree with each other, and you will not agree with all of them, but they will give you categories for thinking about the Christian faith that the thin toolkit does not provide. They will show you that the faith is more durable, more interesting, and more capable of bearing intellectual weight than the evangelicalism you left had told you.

The fifth piece is the recovery of a long view of time. American

evangelicalism, because it is relatively young, tends to operate with a short memory. It talks about the early church, it has access to the creeds, but its felt time horizon is usually the last forty years. Something is judged successful if the pastor's podcast is growing. Something is judged true if the contemporary evangelical consensus affirms it. This short horizon makes the tradition feel less stable than it is. When the contemporary consensus shifts, as it does every decade or two, the person whose only time frame is the current consensus feels the ground shift under them. The deconstructor on the reconstructive path has to acquire a longer time horizon. She has to learn to read the church across centuries rather than across recent podcasts. She has to develop an instinct for which claims have been held by the church, in every time and place, and which claims are the specific enthusiasms of the current North American moment. That instinct is the antidote to both the reactive traditionalism that rejects everything new and the rootless progressivism that accepts whatever the current consensus says. The instinct is formed, over time, by reading widely and thinking across centuries.

The sixth piece is the recovery of suffering as a category of Christian experience that is not primarily a problem to be solved. Much of the American evangelical framework treats suffering as an anomaly. Why would a good God let this happen. The Great Tradition treats suffering as central, not peripheral. The cross is at the center of Christian faith. The martyrs are named every year on the liturgical calendar. The monastic tradition has built its whole practice around a recognition that the Christian life is, in significant part, a willing entry into the suffering of Christ. The deconstructor who has been told that suffering is a problem the faith is supposed to solve has been given a version of the faith that the actual tradition does not hold. The actual tradition holds that suffering is real, that suffering is entered into rather than avoided, that God is present in the suffering rather than explaining it away, and that the resurrection is the final word but that the cross is the precondition of the resurrection. This reframing can save a person who has been trying to hold a version of Christianity that pretended the cross was avoidable.

The seventh piece, and the one that many deconstructors find the hardest, is the recovery of obedience. Somewhere in the deconstruction process, obedience tends to get pushed to the margin. The deconstructor, with good reason, has come to distrust the authorities that demanded obedience, and has come to see the demand itself as manipulation. Over time, however, a faith without any obedience becomes indistinguishable from a lifestyle preference. The reconstructive path, eventually, requires the rediscovery of the yes. Not the yes that is coerced by abusive authority. Not the yes that comes from wanting to fit in with a tribe. The yes that comes from saying, I have looked at the teachings of Jesus, I have looked at the alternatives my culture is offering me, and I conclude that I would rather live inside the teachings of Jesus, with all their cost, than inside the alternatives, with all their different costs. That yes, chosen freely, against the grain of the ambient culture, is what the church in every age has meant by faith. The deconstructor who reaches it has not returned to the starting point. She has arrived at something the starting point could not have produced, because the starting point had not been tested.

A word on the difficulty of this timeline. What I have described is a long process. It is not the six-week course the church sometimes offers the deconstructor to bring her back. It is years. It is a reading list, a search for community, a practice of disciplines, a development of intellectual resources, a cultivation of the long view, a reframing of suffering, and an eventual rediscovery of obedience. Most deconstructors who make it through will tell you it took five to ten years. The church that wants them back has to be willing to be present for the whole process without demanding accelerated milestones. Most churches are not willing. Be the exception.

A word on what the church owes the reconstructor, as distinct from the deconstructor. The deconstructor needs space, acknowledgment, and patience. The reconstructor, the one who is trying to build something on the other side, needs more active resources. She needs reading recommendations. She needs a mentor.

She needs a liturgy and a practice and a community that can carry the weight of the faith she is trying to rebuild. She needs the pastor who will meet her once a month for a year and talk through what she is reading. She needs the church that will let her participate even before she has completed the reconstruction. These things cost the church something. They cost time, money, patience, and a willingness to host the incomplete faith of the person who is on her way. A church that cannot pay these costs will not help the reconstructor. A church that will pay them will gain, in her, a member whose faith, when it finally lands, is more robust and more contagious than the faith of many lifelong members.

Let me end the chapter with a specific image. A friend of mine, a woman who went through a long and painful deconstruction after spiritual abuse in her childhood church, told me recently that what finally held her on the reconstructive path was not a single conversation or a single book. It was a small Anglican parish that let her sit in the back during compline every Sunday night for two years before she said a word to anyone. She did not join. She did not profess faith. She did not tithe. She sat in the back, during the hour when the rest of the world was running, and let the prayers and the candles and the Psalms do their slow work on her. After two years, she asked the priest if she could talk with him about some questions. He said, yes, and I am glad you came back. He did not say, where have you been. He did not say, what took you so long. He said, I am glad you came back. They talked for a year. After the year, she asked if she could be baptized, because her childhood baptism felt too entangled with what had happened to her. The priest, after due discernment, said yes. She was baptized on the Easter Vigil, thirty-five years old. At the reception after the baptism, she told the small group of friends who had come to witness it, I never thought I would stand in a church again. Here I am.

The church that can cultivate this shape has a future. The church that cannot, does not.

CHAPTER 16

The Church We Could Still Become

I have spent fifteen chapters describing what has gone wrong and what the honest response to it looks like. I want to spend this chapter describing what a congregation could look like if it took the diagnosis seriously and built its common life around the response. This is not a utopia. It is not a model that will fit every context. It is a composite sketch, drawn from congregations I have visited, pastors I have learned from, and the work my own church has been trying to do, imperfectly, for some years. The sketch is offered as encouragement, not prescription. Take what is useful. Leave what is not. Build what your people need.

The first feature of the church we could still become is that it tells the truth about itself. It does not perform. It does not brand. It does not stage an emotional experience that will be judged by the quality of the music and the production value of the lighting. It tells the truth about what it is and what it has been. It says, from the pulpit, that the church has failed the watching world in ways that account for much of what we are living through. It does not blame the culture for rejecting a caricature the church itself supplied. It does not gaslight its own young people about what they saw. It names the failures specifically. The sex abuse cover-ups. The political captivity. The financial scandals. The purity culture that damaged a generation. The doctrine of hell that was preached more vividly than the love of Christ. The flag in the sanctuary. It names these things, not as rhetorical throat-clearing, but as the actual conditions under which it is attempting to rebuild.

Truth-telling of this kind is not a one-off. It is a culture. It is a way the pastor speaks every week, a way the elders operate, a way the members are trained to speak about the church. The young adult

who comes back for the first Sunday in six years, hesitantly, and hears the pastor in the pulpit say something true about Ravi Zacharias or about the SBC report or about the election, feels something she has not felt in a church in a long time. She feels that the pulpit is in the same world she is in. That feeling is more evangelistically powerful than every outreach campaign the church has ever run.

The second feature is structural accountability. The church that has told the truth has also, by that telling, exposed itself to the question of how it will prevent the failures from happening again. This question does not answer itself. It is answered by structures. Not slogans. Not prayers. Structures. The church has a publicly available policy for how allegations of misconduct will be handled. The policy does not route through the accused. It routes through an independent party, external to the staff and the eldership, whose job is to investigate. The church uses a background check system on every person in children's and youth ministry. The church has a two-adult rule that is actually enforced, with consequences for violation. The church has a conflict of interest policy for the pastor's compensation, travel, and outside income. The church has term limits on elders so that no single group becomes entrenched. The church submits to outside review of its finances annually. The church has an ombudsperson or equivalent role to whom any member can bring a concern without going through the person they are concerned about. None of these structures are exotic. They are ordinary. They cost nothing except humility. The refusal to implement them is itself a signal about what the church actually values.

The third feature is liturgical depth. The church that has been doing a ninety-minute production will have to learn, again, to do worship. I mean worship in the ancient sense. The church gathers. It confesses its sins together, aloud, using language that has been prayed by Christians for centuries. It hears the Word read in multiple passages, not only the one the pastor will preach on. It says the Creed. It sings, but not only the songs of the last five years. It sings hymns that have carried the faith across generations. It prays the

Lord's Prayer together. It celebrates the Eucharist more often than once a quarter. It observes the liturgical calendar, not because the calendar is magic, but because the calendar gives the congregation a shape for its year that is not determined by the shape of the retail calendar or the sports calendar. Advent, Christmas, Epiphany, Lent, Easter, Pentecost, Ordinary Time. The year takes its shape from the story of Christ. The congregation learns, without quite knowing they are learning, that the story of Christ is the story they live inside.

Many American evangelicals have received a form of worship that has carefully avoided most of these elements, often on the implicit theory that the elements are Catholic or high church or dead religion. They are none of those things. They are the worship of the church across two thousand years. The contemporary evangelical service that has stripped them out is the innovation, not the tradition. Restoring them is not a move toward formality at the expense of life. It is a move toward the forms that, in every age, have proved capable of carrying the faith through periods of cultural upheaval. The periods we are entering will require worship that can carry weight. The praise band and the preaching teachable moment are lighter forms than what is coming will demand.

The fourth feature is catechesis, which is a word most evangelicals have not used for a hundred years and which means, simply, teaching the faith in a structured way to people who want to learn it. The American evangelical church has largely assumed that faith would be absorbed by osmosis, from Sunday services and youth groups and small groups and family devotions. The assumption has not held. The generation raised in evangelical households has absorbed something, but it is not the faith. It is a set of cultural markers, a few verses, a set of political reflexes, and a vague sense that God wants them to be happy. The faith itself, as a structured body of belief and practice, has not been transmitted. That is a catechetical failure.

The church we could become takes this failure seriously. It develops a catechism, or adopts a historic one, or works through a

classical one like the Heidelberg Catechism or Luther's Small Catechism. It runs a program in which every new member, regardless of age, spends a year going through it before joining. It runs a similar program with its teenagers, in which the confirmation class, or its equivalent, is not a rite of passage but a year of serious engagement with the historic faith, covering the creeds, the sacraments, the Lord's Prayer, the Ten Commandments, the Beatitudes, the major doctrines, and the devotional practices that have sustained Christians through hard times. The graduates of this program are not theologically certified. They are, however, formed in a way that most American evangelicals have never been formed, and they will be able to hold, under pressure, what a thinner evangelical formation would have released.

****The fifth feature is a real theology of suffering.**** A church that teaches a real theology of suffering also, by the same curriculum, disarms the prosperity reflex that has crept into every corner of American Christianity, including corners that would reject the prosperity gospel by name. The reflex assumes that if you are faithful, things will work out. That assumption is not biblical. It is American. Separating it out, week by week, for years, will cost the preacher something. The congregation is not going to love, at first, the sermons that tell the truth about what the Christian life actually costs. Stay with it. Over time, the congregation that gets a faith with its full weight in the picture will be more resilient, more capable of serving suffering neighbors, and more recognizable as the church of Jesus Christ than the congregation down the street that is still promising that God has a plan and everything will work out.

The sixth feature is a reimagined ecclesiology of friendship, singleness, and family. The American evangelical church has, for several generations, centered the nuclear family in a way that has left single adults, divorced adults, childless adults, and adults whose families are in disarray as marginal participants in congregational life. The centering has been done in the name of family values, but it has had the effect of making many Christians feel that they are not

full Christians unless they have the right kind of family. This is a theology the New Testament does not teach. Jesus, Paul, and most of the early church's missionary leadership were single. The church was a family that transcended biological family. The congregation was where the childless woman found mothering to do, where the orphan found fathers and brothers, where the person with no blood kin found kin.

A congregation that reimagines itself along these lines will develop durable practices of friendship. It will host meals that bring single adults and families together regularly and in equal standing, not as guests but as participants. It will treat celibacy as a vocation that the church needs, not as a consolation prize for those who did not find a spouse. It will teach on sexual ethics in ways that integrate single adults, gay Christians who hold to the traditional ethic, widows, divorced adults, and couples, without making anyone feel they are living a lesser version of the faith. It will develop relational structures that let congregants be known, cared for, and accountable across the stages of life. It will not assume that the highest good of a person is marriage and children. It will assume that the highest good of a person is union with Christ, lived out in community, in whatever configuration of life God has given them. The single adult and the gay Christian and the childless couple and the divorced mother, in that congregation, will not feel that they are tolerated. They will feel that they are at home. Because they will be.

The church we could become also takes the intellectual life of its members seriously. It has a teaching ministry that is more than a Sunday sermon. It runs reading groups. It runs classes on the historic creeds and on the great Christian thinkers. It hosts speakers who can engage serious questions about science, philosophy, ethics, and history. It has a library, physical or digital, that its members can use. It models, from the pulpit, the reading of serious books. Its pastor reads more than the books of his immediate subculture. Its members know that their intellectual questions are welcome, that they will be answered with seriousness, and that nobody in the congregation is

going to be looked at strangely for asking them.

The intellectual life I am describing is not academic in the bad sense. It is not pretentious. It is not about credentialing. It is about a congregation that believes its faith is true, that the truth of the faith can bear scrutiny, that scrutiny is therefore welcome, and that the life of the mind is part of the love of God with heart, soul, mind, and strength. The church that has been afraid of its own mind has bred Christians who cannot sustain a conversation with an unbelieving colleague, a skeptical child, or a doubting spouse. The church that has trained its mind has bred Christians who can talk about their faith without flinching, because they have, in fact, thought about it.

The seventh feature is a posture toward the world that is neither retreat nor conquest. The American evangelical church has oscillated, for a century, between two equally unhealthy postures. The first is retreat, in which the church circles the wagons, treats the broader culture as the enemy, and raises its children inside a bubble in the hope of keeping them uncontaminated. The second is conquest, in which the church sees the culture as territory to be taken, builds political campaigns and media empires to take it, and measures faithfulness by the amount of cultural power it has accumulated. Neither posture is the posture of Christ. Christ was neither a monastic nor a political operative. He was a rabbi who walked into the villages, sat at the tables of the unrighteous, spoke the truth, suffered for it, and rose from the dead. His followers, in imitation, have always been most faithful when they have lived as residents of the kingdom of God in the kingdom of this world, neither fleeing it nor seeking to rule it, but being present in it as witnesses, servants, friends, neighbors, and, when necessary, martyrs.

The congregation I am describing models this posture. It is engaged with its city, its schools, its social problems, its homeless, its addicted, its abused, its bereaved. It is not engaged because it wants to win or because it wants to look good or because it is running a program. It is engaged because its Lord is engaged, and where the Lord goes, the church follows. Its politics are not the politics of a

party. Its politics are the politics of the Sermon on the Mount, applied with discernment, unevenly matching either political coalition, critical of both, loyal to Christ, loving its enemies, refusing to hate. This posture will make enemies in every tribe. The congregation that can absorb the hatred of every tribe and still love the enemies who send it, is recognizably the congregation of Jesus Christ. The congregation that has been adopted by one tribe and is cheered by that tribe, is something else, whatever its self-description.

The eighth feature is generational patience. The church I am describing does not expect to reverse the cultural slide in five years. It does not expect its children to all return. It does not expect its community to notice its faithfulness. It is playing a long game that it may lose, in its current institutional form, in its own lifetime. It is content to lose that game, because it knows that the game it is actually playing is not played on those stakes. It is playing the game of handing on the faith, faithfully, to whatever remnant will receive it, trusting the Spirit with the rest. It is prepared to become smaller, poorer, and less culturally visible. It is also prepared, if the Spirit wills, to become an unexpected source of life for a generation that has given up on the institutions it left. Either way, it is not measuring itself by the metrics of growth, influence, or relevance that have ruined so many of its peers. It is measuring itself by fidelity.

I will say this as directly as I can. The churches that survive the next forty years in anything like a recognizable Christian form will not be the churches that ran the biggest conferences, produced the most popular podcasts, or had the most political influence at their peak. The churches that survive will be the churches that did the quiet, unglamorous work of being present to the people in their neighborhoods, teaching the faith carefully to the children in their care, practicing the disciplines of prayer and sacrament with patience over years, telling the truth about their failures, and trusting God with the rest. Many of those churches are small. Many of them are obscure. Many of them will never be written about. But they exist, and they are, right now, the seed crystal from which Christianity in

this country will, if it continues, continue.

The ninth feature is love for the people who have left. This is the feature I want to end on, because it is the one the deconstructor needs to hear and the one the church has forgotten. The church we could become does not write off the people who have left. It does not treat them as apostates or as cautionary tales. It does not speak about them as lost causes or as enemies. It holds them. It prays for them by name. It welcomes them back, when and if they return, without demanding that they explain themselves, catch up on what they missed, or perform the testimony that would close the loop. It sits with them in their unbelief. It remembers them on Sunday. It is the father on the porch, every evening, watching the road.

The deconstructor reading this chapter may, even now, be thinking, I have never been in a church like what he is describing. I want to say two things about that. First, the church I am describing exists in fragments and approximations, in various places, and it is possible you could find one. Try again. Not all churches are the church you left. Second, if you cannot find the church I am describing, you can help build it. The person who walked away from a broken institution because the institution was broken is not under obligation to go back to a broken institution. That person is, however, available, as a member of the body of Christ that has not ceased to exist, to help some local congregation become the thing it should have been all along. The shortage of trustworthy churches is not going to fix itself. It will be fixed, if it is fixed, by people who have seen what is wrong and who have the conviction, the pain, and the residual faith to help build the alternative. If you are such a person, the church needs you. It has not treated you well. It is asking, nonetheless, whether you will come back, not to the institution that hurt you, but to the Lord who has not stopped loving you, and whether, as part of that coming back, you will lend your hand to the slow work of making the next version of the institution something less hurtful and more faithful.

This is the church we could still become. It is not a church of the

future. It is a church that, in scattered forms, has always existed in the history of the Christian people, and that is struggling to be born again in our generation, in the aftermath of a collapse that was, in many ways, the judgment of God on what the church had become. Judgment is not the last word. Judgment in the biblical imagination is the prelude to mercy. The collapse is the prelude to whatever comes next. What comes next depends, in part, on what the remnant does with the materials it has been given and the hour it is living through. The question is not whether the materials exist. The question is whether we have the courage to take them up and use them. It is the gift that never runs out, and it is available, tonight, to anyone who is willing to receive it and act on it. That is what I am praying for, for my congregation, for the reader of this book, and for the church in this country that has wandered far and that is being called, still, with kindness, home.

CHAPTER 17

Parents of Deconstructors: A Long Letter to the Mothers and Fathers

This chapter is for the parents. It is the longest single demographic among my readers, and it is the demographic most often left out of the conversation about deconstruction, except as cautionary tales or as sympathy cases. The parents of deconstructors are neither. They are, in many cases, people of deep faith who are carrying a grief that has no obvious vocabulary and no clear resolution. They did what they knew to do. They took the children to church. They did the devotions. They prayed the prayers. They paid for the Christian school, or they modeled the family altar, or they led the youth group, or they hosted the small group. They watched their child grow up, profess faith, maybe even get baptized, and then, in high school or in college or in the first hard year out of college, walk away. The child is not always angry. Sometimes the child is kind. The child still calls. The child still shows up at Christmas. The child simply does not believe anymore, or does not believe the way the parent believes, and the parent is left with a question that has no answer the parent can accept. What did I do wrong. What could I have done differently. Am I being judged for some failure I cannot see.

I have had this conversation with dozens of parents. The conversation is always the same and always different. The sameness is in the grief. The difference is in the specifics, because every family is its own country with its own history, and the specifics matter. What I want to do in this chapter is offer some counsel, drawn from those conversations and from my own work, that may help the parent reading this page find a way to stand inside the situation without breaking. I am a parent myself. I have five sons. I cannot claim to be

immune to the fear that animates this chapter. I can only claim to have thought about it for a long time and to have watched, over years, what helps and what does not.

The first thing I want to say is that your child's deconstruction is not, in most cases, the verdict on your parenting you are reading it as. You are reading it that way because the evangelical culture taught you to read it that way. It taught you that if you did your job as a parent, the child would walk with the Lord. It taught you that Proverbs 22:6, train up a child in the way he should go and when he is old he will not depart from it, was a promise rather than a general principle. It taught you that children who walked away were children of parents who had not been faithful enough. That teaching was wrong. It was Americanized pragmatism dressed in biblical language. It was the prosperity gospel applied to parenting. The actual biblical picture is more complicated and less reassuring. The actual biblical picture includes Samuel, whose sons were corrupt. David, whose sons were corrupt. Eli, whose sons were corrupt. Hosea, whose marriage was a parable for Israel's unfaithfulness. Even God himself, in the prophets' accounting, is the parent who raised children only to have them turn against him. If the pattern is present in the Bible, the pattern is not a failure of parenting. It is a feature of the relationship between finite parents and finite children in a broken world.

You are not Samuel. You are not David. You are also not, thank God, required to be. You are a parent who did your best inside your limits, and whose child, being an adult, is making her own decisions. Her decisions do not belong to you. They were never going to belong to you. The fantasy that you could guarantee her faith by the quality of your parenting was a fantasy. Let the fantasy go. The guilt that it has been producing in you is not from the Lord. The Lord, in fact, has a long record of working patiently with people whose parents were terrible and whose children were worse. He is working patiently with yours too. Let him.

The second thing I want to say is that your relationship with your child is more important than her current theological position. I know

that sounds like the kind of thing a therapist says to soften your conviction. I am not a therapist, and I am not softening anything. I am saying that the thing you have, and can maintain, and can build on, is the relationship. The thing you cannot control, and should not try to manage, is her theology. Spend your energy on the relationship. Save your theological energy for your own spiritual life, for your pastor, for your small group. Do not bring the theology to the dinner table unless she brings it first. Do not preface every phone call with a subtle check-in about her spiritual temperature. Do not send the articles you have been saving up. Do not forward the podcast episode. She knows where you stand. You have told her with your life. She is not failing to become a Christian because she has not received enough information. She has plenty of information. She is working something out. Your job, for the duration of the working out, is to love her in a way that makes the relationship a place she wants to be.

This counsel is harder than it sounds. The parent I am describing is going to have to sit through Thanksgiving dinners in which the child's new boyfriend says things about religion that the parent knows to be false, and the parent will have to bite her tongue. The parent is going to have to hear, from her child, criticisms of the church that the parent has loved for fifty years, and the parent will have to, in some cases, agree with them, even when the agreement costs her. The parent is going to have to welcome the child home, for weekends and holidays, without treating the child like a project, without scheduling in pointed conversations, without introducing the visiting pastor to the child with a meaningful look. Every instinct the parent has been trained in will be pulling the other way. She will have to resist every one of those instincts, out of love for the child, who is the person in front of her and not a theological case study.

The third thing I want to say is that the years may be longer than you are used to thinking. Most of what I have said about deconstruction has emphasized that it takes time. The timeline for the child may be five years. It may be ten. It may be twenty. The parent who has been assuming, in the back of her mind, that this is a phase

that will pass by next Christmas, is not going to make it through this with her soul intact. She will burn out on hope, then burn out on despair, then settle into a low-grade resentment that will poison everything. The parent who can adjust her internal clock to the actual timeline of the thing, who can say, I am in this for the next twenty years, who can then ask, what does faithful love look like over twenty years, will do much better. That parent will not be grasping at each conversation for the sign that her child is turning. She will have released that demand. She will simply be the mother or the father who keeps loving, keeps praying, keeps offering the relationship, and waits.

Prayer deserves a section of its own. The parent whose child has deconstructed is tempted, at various points in the process, to give up on prayer. The prayers have not worked. The child is further from the faith than she was five years ago. Why keep praying. I understand the temptation. It should be resisted. Keep praying, and change what you are praying for. You have probably been praying, for years, something like, Lord, bring her back to faith. That prayer is not wrong. It is, however, a prayer about a specific outcome, and it can wear you down when the outcome does not arrive on your timeline. Try, instead, praying prayers that you can verify are being answered in real time. Pray for her protection today. Pray for her to have a kind person in her life today. Pray that she will feel loved today, by you and by whoever else is in her orbit. Pray that God will be present to her in whatever way she can receive him today. These prayers are answered, most days, in small ways you will not always see but can trust. They keep the line of prayer open. They form you, the parent, into a person who is practicing trust in the thing you cannot see rather than demanding evidence you cannot produce. They also, over years, soften your own heart in ways that help the relationship. The child who comes home for the weekend and finds a parent softer than she expected is the child who may, over time, bring more of herself back into the conversation.

A word about your community. The parent of a deconstructor

often feels ashamed in church. The church has often been the source of the shame, even when it did not intend to be. The parent sits through sermons about raising children in the fear of the Lord and feels like a fraud. The parent hears testimonies from other families about children who love Jesus and feels judged by implication. The parent begins to dread the pew. This is understandable, and it is also, if it continues, going to isolate the parent at exactly the moment she most needs support. Find a community, inside your church or outside of it, where you can be honest about what you are carrying. The community may be one other couple. It may be a small group of parents in similar situations. It may be a counselor who understands the specific grief. It may be, if your own church cannot hold it, a different church. Do not suffer this alone. The enemy of your soul, during this stretch, is isolation. Resist isolation at every cost.

Another word, about your spouse. If you are married, the deconstruction of a child is going to test the marriage in ways you did not anticipate. You and your spouse will process the grief on different timelines. One of you will want to talk about it more; the other will want to talk about it less. One of you will see signs of hope; the other will see signs of loss. One of you will blame yourself; the other will, in a weak moment, blame you. Marriages have ended over this. Do not let yours be one of them. Put the marriage first. Go to counseling if you need to. Agree, explicitly, that neither of you will weaponize the child's situation against the other. Make the marriage a safe place for both of you to grieve honestly without making it worse. The children are watching, including the child who has left. A marriage that survives this, with dignity, is a powerful witness. A marriage that does not, confirms for the child who has left the worst suspicions she had about what faith produces under pressure.

I want to address, specifically, the parent whose child has rejected not only the theology but the parent. This is the hardest case. The child has decided that the parent was part of the problem. The child has, in some cases, gone no-contact or low-contact. The child is telling other people a story about the parent's faith-shaped parenting

that the parent, from inside, does not recognize. This is grief compounded by powerlessness. I will not pretend to have a formula. I will say a few things. Examine the story she is telling as if it were from a stranger. Some of it may be more accurate than you can currently admit. The reflex to defend yourself is understandable but counterproductive. Where the story is accurate, acknowledge it, even if the acknowledgment is not invited. A letter, sent without demand for response, saying, I have been thinking about some things you said, and you were right about some of them, here is what I see, I am sorry, can do more than you expect. Do not expect it to work quickly. Do not expect it to work at all. Do it anyway, because it is true. Where the story is not accurate, stay silent, for now. Defending yourself to someone who is not ready to hear the defense will harden the position. Time, kindness, consistent presence from a distance, and the Spirit do work that argument cannot do. Trust that work.

There is a version of this chapter in which I would spend more time on practical tactics. What to say, what not to say, how to handle Christmas, how to respond to a social media post that horrifies you. I have not spent much time on those tactics because I have come to believe that the tactics follow from the posture, and the posture is the thing that is hard. The parent who has the right posture will figure out the tactics. The parent who does not, will not, no matter how many tactics she reads about. The posture is this. Your child is a person. Her relationship with God is not your responsibility to guarantee. Your love for her is unconditional and uncoerced. Your hope is in a God who is patient beyond your patience. Your prayer is that he will do what you cannot. Your presence, in her life, is a gift you give her without expectation. Your own faith does not depend on her faith. Your identity as a Christian is not contingent on her outcomes. Hold that posture. Build your life around it. The years will pass. You will not always see progress. You will, over time, find that the grief has become something closer to love, and that the love has become something closer to peace, even in the uncertainty. That is what parenting looks like, in this situation, when parenting goes well. It is not the happy ending you were hoping for. It is a different kind of

happy, closer to the peace of Christ, who was himself left by people he loved, and who continued to love them anyway.

I want to end the chapter with a story. A woman in my congregation, seventy-one years old, lost her son to the deconstruction wave twenty years ago. He is now in his mid-forties. She has prayed for him every day of those twenty years. She has been careful not to badger him. She has welcomed him home, and his wife, and their children, for every holiday. She has spoken about the faith only when he has asked. She has, in the last several years, watched him begin to ask about certain things, tentatively, around the edges. She does not know whether he will ever return. She told me recently that she had made her peace with not knowing. She said, I have concluded that my job is to love him, and God's job is to save him, and I am not going to mix up the jobs anymore. When I heard her say that, I heard the voice of a saint. That voice has been formed over twenty years of grief held inside prayer. It is the voice the parent of a deconstructor can grow into, if she is willing to let the grief be slowly worked by the Spirit into something that does not destroy her but that instead forms her into the kind of Christian her child, if she ever comes home, will be glad to see.

CHAPTER 18

Pastors in the Aftermath: When Your Congregation Is the One They Left

Every conversation about deconstruction is, at some point, also a conversation about the pastor. Not the celebrity pastor whose fall caused the crisis. The ordinary pastor. The one who did not cover up the abuse, did not run a celebrity empire, did not fly private, did not build a brand. The one who has been preaching three times a week, visiting the hospital on Tuesdays, counseling the divorcing couple on Wednesdays, meeting with the deacons on Thursdays, working on Sunday's sermon on Friday night because the week got away from him again. That pastor is not the problem the deconstructors left. He is, nonetheless, standing in the middle of the aftermath, trying to figure out what to do next. This chapter is for him.

What the pastor is carrying, often without recognizing it, is a compound grief. There is the grief of loss, because he has watched members leave his congregation over the last decade, and some of those members are people he loved, people he baptized, people whose children he dedicated, people he assumed he would bury. They have not asked him to bury them. They have not called in two years. There is the grief of confusion, because he is not sure what he did wrong, not sure that he did anything wrong, and not sure whether the distinction matters when the pews are thinner than they used to be. There is the grief of a cultural mood that has put the pastor, as a category, on the defensive. Pastoral trust has never been lower in his lifetime. He walks into the barbershop and mentions what he does for a living and sees the shift in the other person's eyes. The shift is not hostile. It is worse. It is indifferent, or mildly suspicious, or pitying, as if the pastor were the last believer in a dead system.

These griefs compound over years. The pastor does not talk about them because he was trained not to. The training was, in many cases, implicit. Nobody told him he could not talk about his own confusion. The culture of pastoral leadership simply modeled a confidence that did not have room for the confusion he was feeling. He preaches on faith. He preaches on trust. He preaches on the hope of the church. He does these things while carrying, privately, the weight of what does not seem to be working. The weight shows up in his body. It shows up in his sleep. It shows up in his marriage, in ways his wife can see and he cannot.

Here is what I want to say to that pastor. The problem is real. The confusion is legitimate. The grief is not a sign of failure. It is a sign that you are paying attention. The pastor who is not carrying some version of this grief in the current moment is either so insulated from the cultural situation that he has not noticed it, or so hardened against it that he has stopped feeling. Neither condition is preferable to yours. You are awake. You are honest. Start there.

The first practical matter is your own theological formation. Many pastors, if they are honest, stopped their own theological reading somewhere around the time the ministry demands consumed their schedules. They read in seminary. They read their favorite preachers and their favorite podcast guests. They stopped reading the difficult books because the difficult books require time they do not have and mental energy that feels like a luxury. The result, over a decade, is a pastor whose theological resources have not expanded beyond what he had at twenty-six. That pastor is now trying to answer questions from a generation that has read broadly and that expects the pastor to have read broadly too. When the pastor has not, the conversation fails. The young adult walks away concluding that the church does not have the resources to handle her questions. The church may have the resources. The pastor does not have them at hand.

This is fixable. Read. Read more than the preachers in your tribe. Read the people your deconstructing members are reading. Read

Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age*, even if it takes you a year. Read David Bentley Hart, even if you disagree with him. Read Marilynne Robinson. Read N. T. Wright's longer works, not the popular summaries. Read the early church fathers, even in translation. Read one difficult theological book per quarter, and make space in your schedule as if it were a hospital visit, because it is. Your mind is the instrument through which you serve your congregation. When you stop feeding it, the instrument goes dull. A dull instrument produces dull sermons, and dull sermons are, at this moment in the church's life, a luxury nobody can afford.

The second matter is how you preach. The deconstructors in your pew, and the pre-deconstructors, and the parents of deconstructors, are all listening for the same thing. They are listening for honesty. They are listening for a sign that the pastor knows the world they are living in. They are listening for evidence that the pastor has considered the best version of the objections they are carrying, not the straw-man version. A sermon that addresses the real questions the real people in the room are asking, and that gives those questions their full weight before responding, is a sermon that earns trust. A sermon that waves at the questions on the way to the pre-scheduled application point is a sermon that spends trust. You do not have enough trust to keep spending it.

Let me be specific about what this preaching looks like. It means, sometimes, spending the first third of the sermon on the objection rather than on the answer. It means describing the deconstructor's experience in terms the deconstructor would recognize, rather than in terms that caricature it. It means saying, from the pulpit, I understand why someone would leave over this. That sentence, spoken honestly, does more to establish your credibility than a year of sermon introductions designed to be relatable. The congregation that hears you take the objection seriously will trust you when you give the response. The congregation that hears you dismiss it will conclude you do not understand their world, and the conclusion will be correct.

The third matter is the pastoral conversation. Most pastors, when

they learn that a congregant is deconstructing, make a series of predictable mistakes. They schedule a meeting too quickly. They come to the meeting with an agenda. The agenda is, usually, to identify the doctrinal issues and to supply the corrective. The conversation becomes an informal exam. The deconstructor, who has agreed to the meeting out of residual loyalty, senses that she is being processed rather than heard. She answers politely. She does not come back for the second meeting.

Here is a different approach. When you learn that a congregant is deconstructing, do nothing pastoral for a while. Pray. Let the information settle. Then, when you see the person next, ask her to get coffee. Do not set an agenda. Do not call it counseling. Over coffee, ask her one question and then listen. The question is this. What has been happening for you in the last year or two. That is the whole question. Everything the person says in response to that question is material you need. Listen without rebutting. Listen without planning your response. Listen past the first answer and the second answer and into the third answer, which is usually the real one. When the real answer comes, stay with it. Do not immediately apply the scriptural corrective. The corrective may come, later, in a different conversation, when the person has had the experience of being heard by a representative of the institution that she felt never heard her. The hearing is the first ministry. Everything else depends on it.

The fourth matter is grief counseling, for you. You need someone to talk to about this. Your spouse is not the right person, not because she does not care, but because she carries her own version of the grief, and the last thing she needs is to be your therapist. A counselor or a spiritual director or a peer group of pastors in similar situations is what you need. If your denomination provides pastoral counseling, use it. If it does not, find one. Pay for it out of the continuing education budget if your church has one. If you cannot afford it, ask a denominational leader for help. If the denomination does not have help, the Pastors Connection Network exists for this reason among others.

The fifth matter is what you tell your congregation about the people who have left. The temptation is to say nothing, because saying something feels like airing dirty laundry. The result is a silence that the remaining congregation fills with its own stories, which are usually worse than the truth. A better approach is to name the reality, generally, without naming names. Something like this, from the pulpit, at the right time. Some of you have noticed that people you love are no longer here. You are right. People have left. Some of them have left because we failed them, and we need to own that. Some of them have left because they are working through questions that take time. Some of them have left for reasons we do not know. What I want to say is that we pray for them. We hold the door open for them. We do not talk about them as if they are enemies or as if they are projects. We love them. And I want to ask you to do something that may feel strange. I want you to reach out to them. Not to invite them to an event. Not to share a link. To let them know that you miss them and that there is no agenda attached. That is what this church does with the people it has lost. We do not drop them. We carry them.

That language, from the pulpit, does two things at once. It tells the remaining congregation how to treat the people who have left, and it tells the remaining congregation that the pastor sees the situation clearly. Both messages are needed. Both are, in most congregations, unspoken.

The sixth matter is institutional reform. I spent a chapter on the church we could become, and I am not going to repeat that chapter's contents here. What I want to say here is directed at the pastor who reads that chapter and thinks, yes, but my deacons would never go for it, or, my denomination would not allow it. Some of those barriers are real. Some of them are imagined. Determine which is which. The pastor who says my deacons would never allow background checks on youth volunteers has not, in most cases, actually asked the deacons. He has assumed their answer. Ask. Present the case. Bring the data. Let the deacons decide rather than deciding for them. If they

say no, make the case again in six months. If they say no again, decide what you are willing to risk. Every reform in the history of the church has cost someone something. Yours will cost you too. Decide what the cost is worth.

The seventh matter is your own faith. I am going to address this because nobody else will. You are a pastor in the aftermath of a cultural crisis in which the institution you serve has been publicly discredited. That is not a comfortable place to be. It is also, for some pastors, a quietly corrosive place. The doubts that the pastor preaches about on Sundays sometimes visit him on Mondays. The questions the congregation asks are questions he has asked himself. The books the deconstructors are reading are books that have given him pause. The pastor who has experienced this knows what I am talking about. The pastor who has not may experience it in the future.

Here is what I want to say to the pastor who is carrying his own questions. Your questions are legitimate. Your faith is not invalidated by them. The same counsel this book has offered to the deconstructing layperson applies, with some modifications, to you. Read widely. Practice the ancient disciplines. Find a spiritual director. Pray the psalms of lament. You are permitted, as a pastor, to have a complicated faith. You are permitted to hold the questions inside the vocation rather than stepping outside the vocation to hold them. Moses held questions. Jeremiah held questions. The apostles held questions, repeatedly, inside the gospels, often in the form of bewildered looks and wrong answers. You are in their company. Stay in their company. The faith that emerges from this period of questioning, if you stay with it, will be the faith your congregation needs you to have. It will be tested. It will be textured. It will be capable of standing in the pulpit and saying to the doubter, I know the terrain you are describing, because I have walked in it. Come, let us walk in it together. That is the shepherd's voice, and it is the voice the flock in this generation is waiting to hear. It has not heard it often enough.

One final note. The pastoral ministry has always been, in part, a

ministry of holding. You hold the wedding and the funeral. You hold the sick and the confused. You hold the teenager who tried to kill herself and the widow who wants to follow her husband into death. You hold the angry deacon and the worn-out volunteer and the family that is falling apart and the child who was abused and the man who has been drinking again. The holding is not a technique. It is the vocation. What this chapter of the church's life is asking of you is to hold one more thing: the grief and the faith simultaneously. The holding will not be resolved in your lifetime. The crisis will outlast your ministry. What you can do, inside your ministry, is hold it well. Hold it honestly. Hold it without pretending it is not heavy. Hold it inside a faith that has carried heavier things, across worse centuries, and survived. That faith is yours. It has not abandoned you. Hold on.

CONCLUSION

What We Owe Each Other

I want to end this book with a reckoning about what we owe each other, across the line that the deconstruction wave has drawn through our families, our churches, and our friendships. The line is real. There is no sense in pretending it is not there. On one side are people who have continued inside the faith as they have received it. On the other side are people who have left, or who are on their way out, or who are in the middle of a long process of revising what they believe. The two sides have, in many cases, stopped talking. When they talk, they talk past each other. When they write, they write to their own tribe. I have been, in parts of this book, writing to both at once, and I know that means neither side will be fully satisfied with what I have said. I accept that. What I want to do in the conclusion is speak, as directly as I can, to the people on each side of the line about what I think they owe each other. If I do it right, nobody will fully agree and everyone will have something to think about. That is the best I can do.

To the Christians who have stayed inside the faith as they have received it, I want to say this. You owe the people who have left more than you have been giving them. You owe them patience. You owe them honesty. You owe them the acknowledgment that the institution they have left has, in fact, often failed in the ways they say it has failed. You owe them, sometimes, an apology. Not a corporate apology, which is easy and costs nothing. A personal apology, from you to them, for the ways in which your own version of the faith may have been part of what pushed them away. You may not have done any of those things yourself. You may have been faithful the whole time. It does not matter. You are a member of the body that failed them. When members of the body have done wrong, the body confesses. That is how bodies work.

You owe them also your presence. Not your arguments, not your

pamphlets, not your scheduled counseling appointments. Your presence. The willingness to be with them at dinner without steering the conversation toward their soul. The willingness to text them on their birthday without embedding a Bible verse. The willingness to hold them in your mind and your prayers without treating them as projects. Most deconstructors, asked what they would want from the Christians in their lives, would say, first, I would want them to stop trying to fix me. They are not projects. They are people. Treat them as people, and you are most of the way to being the Christian they needed.

You owe them the acknowledgment that you do not know how their story ends. You do not know whether they will come back. You do not know whether they will end up in a different tradition than yours. You do not know whether they will die outside the institutional church but inside some relationship with Christ that you cannot assess. You do not, in fact, have the standing to pronounce on any of this. What you have is the call to love them, over a lifetime, without conditions and without reporting to headquarters. Do that. Leave the outcomes to the one who is actually the judge.

To the Christians who have left, or who are leaving, I want to say something different, and you will have to let me say it even though you are not sure you trust my address. You owe the people you have left more than some of you have been giving them too. You owe them the honesty of admitting that some of your reasons for leaving were reasons and some were rationalizations. You owe them the maturity of not flattening the whole institution into the worst version of it you encountered. You owe them, in many cases, a distinction between the person who hurt you and the tradition that shaped that person, because the tradition, read honestly, would have corrected the person you are rejecting. You owe them patience as they try to figure out how to talk to you. Many of them are scared. Many of them think they have failed you. Many of them do not know how to bring up the subject without making it worse. Give them a little grace. They are people too.

You owe yourself the honesty of finding out what the tradition actually is, before you close the door. Many deconstructors, when I ask them what they have read of the Christian tradition, admit that they have read almost nothing outside the subset of their own former subculture. They have read their old youth pastor and not Augustine. They have read the popular podcast and not Athanasius. They have read their algorithm and not the desert fathers. That is their right. But if they are going to make a final judgment on the faith, they owe themselves, at minimum, the acquaintance with what the faith actually is, in its full historical and theological shape. A judgment rendered without that acquaintance is premature. I do not say that to shame anyone. I say it because the people I have watched make the most stable decisions about the faith, in either direction, are the people who have done the reading. The ones who have not done the reading are the ones who tend to boomerang, oscillating between positions they have not actually understood. Do the reading. The tradition has not asked much of you, and it has been willing to wait.

You owe the next generation more than bitterness. I understand the bitterness. I have felt some of it in rooms I have sat in. The bitterness is warranted. What the bitterness cannot do is form the next generation. A parent whose only religious content with her children is the story of how terrible her childhood religion was has not given her children a faith. She has given them her bitterness. The children will inherit the bitterness without the context that produced it, and the bitterness will do its work on them in ways she did not intend. If you are a parent, consider what you are handing on. The honest story of what you went through is a gift. The bitterness is not. The willingness to seek something better, even if you have not found it yet, is a gift. The shrug is not. Your children are watching. They are not sure what to make of you. Give them enough to work with.

To both sides of the line, I want to say this. The greatest threat to American Christianity right now is not the deconstruction wave and is not the people resisting the deconstruction wave. The greatest threat is the thing that both groups, at their worst, have in common,

which is the refusal to be in relationship with the other. The tribes have hardened. The conversations have stopped. Families that should be sharing Thanksgiving are, instead, communicating through cryptic social media posts about the other side's failures. Pastors who should be friends have stopped taking each other's calls. Old friends who used to serve together in youth ministry now swipe past each other's profiles, assigning each other to a side. This hardening is the death of the one thing that could actually help either side, which is presence. If I could give only one counsel to both groups it would be this. Do not let the line become a wall. The line is real. The wall is optional. Refuse the wall.

Some of what I am describing will require that Christians who have stayed do something specifically. It will require them to stop policing the edges. It will require them to resist the reflex to write off their old friend who no longer posts Bible verses. It will require them to choose, again, that their love for this person is unconditional, not dependent on the person's theological trajectory. That choice, made and re-made, is what kept many deconstructors in the door during their most dangerous years. It can keep others in the door now.

And some of what I am describing will require that Christians who have left do something too. It will require them to resist the mirror-image policing of their own tribe. It will require them to refuse the thrill of the anti-evangelical dunk. It will require them to sit, sometimes, with a family member or old friend who is still inside the faith, and let the family member or old friend be inside the faith without being converted, condescended to, or subjected to a lecture. The relationship matters more than the relative comfort of the positions inside it. Choose the relationship.

A word about the children. Many of the deconstructors who have left are now parents themselves. They are raising children without the church, or with a complicated relationship to the church, or inside a different tradition than the one they grew up in. Those children will grow up with a different set of assumptions than their parents had. They will not know the hymns. They will not know the stories. They

will not carry the same wounds, but they will carry other ones, because growing up without a faith tradition creates its own absences and its own hungers. The church that is thinking about the next generation cannot think only about the children currently in its Sunday school. It has to think about the children of the people who left, because those children are, statistically, the least likely to ever enter a church and the most likely to grow up with no religious vocabulary at all. The question of how to reach them has not been asked often enough. It will need to be asked, and the answers will not look like the answers that worked for the generation before them. The answers will require a church that can speak to people who have never been inside a church, who do not know the language, who do not share the assumptions, and who will not be reached by the methods that worked when America was functionally Christian. That church is being called into existence. It does not yet know its own shape. It will be shaped by the honesty of the people who build it.

I want to close with a word about my own place in all of this. I am a pastor. I have stayed inside the institution. I have, at times, benefited from the institution in ways that deconstructors would rightly notice. I am also a person who has watched this crisis from the inside for many years, and who has had friends leave, and who has had congregants leave, and who has, on occasion, almost left myself. I do not pretend to be neutral. I do not pretend to be unbiased. I am a pastor who has tried, inside this book, to be honest about what the institution has done, honest about what the deconstructors have seen, and honest about where I think the way forward lies. I have probably gotten some things wrong. I have certainly said some things that different readers will hear in different ways. What I have tried not to do is flatter either side. If the book has been uncomfortable to read, I am glad. The subject does not permit a comfortable book.

The God of the Bible is not finished with the church in America. The judgment that has been falling is real, and it is painful, and it is, I believe, deserved. But judgment in the biblical imagination is not the

end of the story. It is the door to repentance, and repentance is the door to renewal, and renewal is what the Spirit is in the business of producing in the churches that have the humility to receive it. I do not know what the American church will look like in twenty years. I do not know how much of the current institutional architecture will survive. I do know that the people of God do not vanish. The gates of hell have not prevailed, and they will not prevail, against the Christ who said they would not. Whatever institutional form the church takes in the next generation, Christ will be at its center, the Scriptures will be in its hands, the sacraments will be at its table, the Spirit will be in its breath, the saints will be in its fellowship, and the broken will be in its pews. That church will not be the one we had. It will be the one God is building. It is worth staying around to help build it. It is worth coming back to, if you have left. It is worth praying for, if you are not sure where you stand.

The conversation is not over. The deconstruction wave is not the last word. What comes after, if we attend to it honestly, can be the chastened, honest, durable Christianity that our children and their children will need. Let us attend to it honestly. Let us tell the truth. Let us love each other across the line that has been drawn. Let us, when the Spirit moves, respond with the only answer the Spirit accepts, which is, here I am.

